LEARN
UNDERSTAND
REVISE
SUCCEED

CURRENT AFFAIRS
STATIC LINKAGES
EXAM FOCUS
VISUAL LEARNING

UPSC CURRENT AFFAIRS THROUGH INFOGRAPHICS

IMPORTANT ISSUES | KEY CONCEPTS | EXAM-ORIENTED INSIGHTS

UPDATED FOR 2026

CONCISE | VISUAL | EXAM FOCUSED | RELIABLE | EASY REVISION

SCO BISHKEK DECLARATION

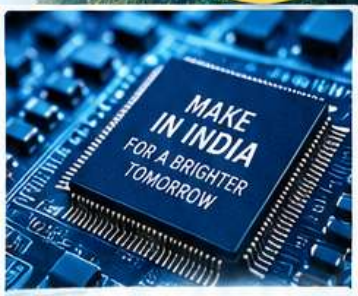
REGIONAL SECURITY & GLOBAL ORDER

IST RULES 2026

TIME FOR A DIGITAL INDIA

INDIA–BELGIUM RELATIONS

TRADE, TECHNOLOGY AND A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP



SEMICON INDIA 2026

SILICON TO SYSTEMS: **BUILDING** THE ECOSYSTEM

MARINE FISHERIES & INDIA'S BLUE ECONOMY

HEALTHY OCEANS PROSPEROUS PEOPLE

AI vs COPYRIGHT LAW

INNOVATION, CREATORS' RIGHTS AND THE ROAD AHEAD

AND MORE KEY DEVELOPMENTS SHAPING INDIA AND THE WORLD

A WELL-INFORMED ASPIRANT BUILDS A STRONGER INDIA

ECONOMY | INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY | ENVIRONMENT | POLITY & GOVERNANCE | SOCIETY | DEVELOPMENT

FOR UPSC AND OTHER COMPETITIVE EXAMS

KNOWLEDGE TODAY A STRONGER TOMORROW

ISRO LAUNCHES
GSLV-F17 / EOS-05

Strengthening India's Earth Observation Capabilities

SPACE FOR
A SAFER, STRONGER
AND A BRIGHTER INDIA

Launch Date	4 September 2026
Launch Vehicle	GSLV-F17 (19th flight of GSLV)
Launch Site	Satish Dhawan Space Centre, Sriharikota
Payload	EOS-05 (Earth Observation Satellite)
Mission Status	Successfully launched

EOS-05
An advanced Earth observation satellite to provide high-resolution images for a wide range of applications.

ABOUT EOS-05

Type	Earth Observation Satellite
Objective	High-resolution imaging of the Earth's surface

Applications
- Agriculture and crop monitoring
- Disaster management
- Forest and environmental monitoring
- Urban and infrastructure planning
- Cartography and resource mapping

Builds on Success of the EOS series (e.g., Cartosat, Resourcesat)

GSLV-F17: KEY FEATURES

- **Three-stage launch vehicle** Solid + Liquid + Cryogenic
- Equipped with an **indigenous cryogenic engine** (CE-7.5)
- **19th flight** of GSLV
- Designed to place heavier satellites in higher orbits
- Demonstrates India's maturity in cryogenic technology

WHY IT MATTERS?

- Enhances India's Earth observation capabilities
- Supports disaster preparedness and climate action
- Aids in sustainable development and resource management
- Strengthens India's self-reliance in space technology
- Contributes to national security and strategic planning

COMPARISON: PSLV vs GSLV vs LVM3

Feature	PSLV	GSLV (Mk II)	LVM3 (Mk III)
Full Form	Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle	Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle	Launch Vehicle Mark 3
Configuration	4-stage (S-L-S-L)	3-stage (S-L-C)	3-stage (S-L-C) with strap-ons
Payload Capacity	~1,750 kg to LEO	~2,500 kg to GTO	~4,000 kg to GTO ~8,000 kg to LEO
Typical Use	Small and medium satellites, Earth observation	Heavier satellites, communication satellites	Very heavy satellites, human spaceflight (Gaganyaan)
Key Highlights	Workhorse of ISRO, high reliability	Uses cryogenic engine (CE-7.5)	Most powerful Indian launch vehicle, enables big missions

WHAT IS A CRYOGENIC ENGINE?

- Uses liquid hydrogen (fuel) and liquid oxygen (oxidiser) at extremely low temperatures.
- Provides high thrust and efficiency.
- Essential for placing heavy satellites in higher orbits (GTO).
- Indigenous cryogenic engine (CE-7.5) marks a major technological milestone for India.

TYPES OF ORBITS

POLAR ORBIT (LEO)

- Low Earth Orbit (LEO) ~500–800 km
- Passes over the poles
- Useful for Earth observation, mapping, surveillance
- Examples: Cartosat, Resourcesat, EOS series

GEOSTATIONARY ORBIT (GEO)

- ~35,786 km above Earth
- Hovers over the equator
- Appears fixed over a point on Earth
- Used for communication, weather satellites
- Examples: INSAT, GSAT series

THE BIGGER PICTURE

- Strengthens India's position as a leading space power
- Supports **Atmanirbhar Bharat** in high-technology sectors
- Enables data-driven governance and development
- Contributes to global efforts on climate change, disaster resilience and sustainable future

INDIA REACHES HIGHER

VIKSIT BHARAT
THROUGH SPACE

GS-III | ECONOMY

FOR A STRONGER INDIA

INDIA'S GDP GROWS 7.8% IN Q1 FY27

Strong domestic demand and record exports support growth

HIGHER GROWTH STRONGER INDIA

Real GDP Growth (Q1 FY27)
7.8%
(Apr–Jun 2026)

India's Goods Exports (June 2026)
$44.24 billion
(Record high)

Key Driver
Strong exports, resilient domestic demand

Challenge
Lower-margin / labour-intensive exports under pressure

WHAT IS GDP?

Gross Domestic Product (GDP) is the total monetary value of all final goods and services produced within a country's borders in a given period of time.

- **Goods** (e.g., food, cars)
- **Services** (e.g., banking, IT)
- Only final output is counted (to avoid double counting)

GDP vs GVA

GDP (Gross Domestic Product)	• Value of all final goods and services • Includes indirect taxes minus subsidies
GVA (Gross Value Added)	• Value added at each stage of production • Does not include indirect taxes and subsidies

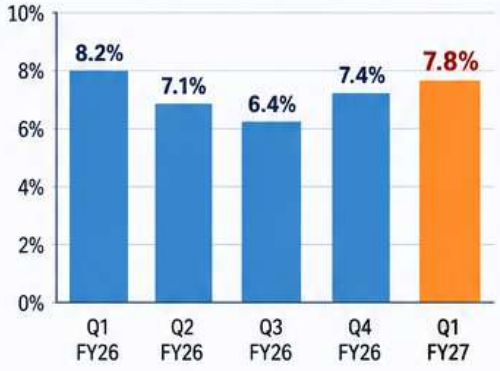
Relationship: GDP = GVA + Indirect Taxes – Subsidies

REAL vs NOMINAL GDP

Nominal GDP	• Measured at current market prices • Affected by inflation
Real GDP	• Measured at constant (base year) prices • Shows actual growth in physical output • Q1 FY27 growth (7.8%) is real GDP growth

TRENDS IN INDIA'S GDP GROWTH

Real GDP Growth Rate (YoY)



HOW GDP IS CALCULATED? (Expenditure Method)

GDP = C + I + G + (X – M)

C	Private Final Consumption Expenditure (Households)
I	Gross Fixed Capital Formation (Investment)
G	Government Final Consumption Expenditure
X	Exports of Goods and Services
M	Imports of Goods and Services (Net exports = X – M)

EXPORTS AND GDP

- India's goods exports rose to $44.24 billion in June 2026 (record high).
- Higher exports increase net exports (X – M), directly adding to GDP.
- Key sectors: engineering goods, petroleum products, electronics, pharmaceuticals, chemicals.
- However, lower-margin and labour-intensive exports face global headwinds (rising competition, trade barriers, slower demand).

WHY GROWTH MATTERS?

- More jobs and higher incomes
- Supports manufacturing and services expansion
- Increases government revenue for welfare and infrastructure
- Helps achieve Viksit Bharat @ 2047

FACTORS SUPPORTING Q1 FY27 GROWTH

- Strong goods exports (record $44.24 billion in June)
- Resilient domestic consumption
- Continued investment activity
- Government capital expenditure
- Stable macroeconomic fundamentals

KEY CHALLENGES AHEAD

- Global economic uncertainty and trade barriers
- Pressure on labour-intensive exports
- Commodity price volatility
- Need to sustain investment and job creation

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. India's real GDP grew 7.8% in Q1 FY27.
2. Exports are a major growth driver, with goods exports at $44.24 billion in June.
3. Understand GDP vs GVA, real vs nominal GDP and the expenditure method.
4. High growth supports jobs, investments and inclusive development, but external risks remain.
5. Sustained reforms and global competitiveness are key for long-term growth.

A STRONG ECONOMY
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

PEOPLE | PRODUCTIVITY | PROSPERITY

VIKSIT BHARAT @ 2047

SCO BISHKEK DECLARATION

Stronger Cooperation for a Stable, Secure and Prosperous Region

SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANISATION

KEY HIGHLIGHTS OF THE BISHKEK DECLARATION

- **Strong opposition to terrorism, separatism and extremism.**
- Rejection of **"double standards"** in counter-terrorism efforts.
- Emphasis on **dialogue and diplomacy** for resolving conflicts.
- Commitment to **regional stability, connectivity and** economic cooperation.

FROM SHANGHAI FIVE TO SCO

- **1996:** Shanghai Five formed by China, Russia, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Tajikistan to build trust and reduce border tensions.
- **2001:** Uzbekistan joined and the grouping was formally transformed into the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO).
- **Gradual expansion** with new members, observers and dialogue partners.

ABOUT SCO

- **Established:** 2001 (evolved from Shanghai Five, 1996)
- **Objective:** Promote regional security, stability, economic cooperation and cultural ties.
- **Nature:** A Eurasian political, economic and security grouping.
- **Secretariat:** Beijing, China
- **Current Chair:** Kyrgyzstan (2026)
- **Next Chair:** Tajikistan (2027)
- **Working Mechanism:** Annual summits, Council of Heads of State, Council of Ministers, RATS, sectoral meetings.

MEMBERS, OBSERVERS & DIALOGUE PARTNERS

Members (10)

India, China, Russia, Pakistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Iran, Belarus

Observer States (2)

Mongolia, Afghanistan

Dialogue Partners (14)

Türkiye, Sri Lanka, Saudi Arabia, UAE, Egypt, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Maldives, Myanmar

(Others: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Cambodia, Nepal)

RATS – REGIONAL ANTI-TERRORIST STRUCTURE

- **Established:** 2004 (Tashkent, Uzbekistan)
- **Function:** Coordinate efforts against terrorism, separatism and extremism.
- **Activities:** Intelligence sharing, capacity building, joint exercises, database of terrorist organisations.
- **Significance:** Institutional mechanism to address common security threats in the region.

INDIA AND SCO

- Joined as a full member in 2017 (along with Pakistan).
- Actively participates in counter-terrorism, connectivity, economic and cultural initiatives.
- At the Bishkek Summit, India reiterated dialogue and diplomacy for resolving conflicts and highlighted the need for a rules-based, multilateral order.
- Supports a united stance against terrorism and rejects double standards.
- Uses SCO as a platform to engage with Central Asian states and Eurasia.

INDIA'S CENTRAL ASIA POLICY

- Strengthen historical and cultural ties with Central Asian countries.
- Expand cooperation in trade, connectivity, energy, defence, critical minerals and education.
- **Key initiatives:** International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC), Chabahar Port, Central Asia–India Dialogue, development partnerships.
- Important for energy security, access to resources and balancing regional powers.
- Part of India's broader "Extended Neighbourhood" and Act East–Connect Central Asia approach.

CHINA/RUSSIA FACTOR

China

- China seeks to use SCO to expand its influence and advance BRI.
- India remains cautious about China's strategic assertiveness.

Russia

- Russia views SCO as a key platform to maintain its influence in Eurasia.
- India continues to engage with Russia while balancing its ties with other partners.

INDIA'S STRATEGIC INTERESTS IN SCO

- Counter-terrorism cooperation.
- Access to Central Asian markets and resources.
- Connectivity (INSTC, Chabahar, regional corridors).
- Balancing China's influence.
- Energy security and critical minerals.
- Supporting a multipolar, rules-based international order.

PEACEFUL NEIGHBOURHOOD
PROSPEROUS REGION
STRONGER INDIA

COOPERATION TODAY
A MORE SECURE TOMORROW

INDIAN STANDARD TIME (IST) RULES 2026

A common, legally enforceable time reference for a digitally connected India

ONE TIME ONE INDIA | ACCURACY RELIABILITY | SECURITY RESILIENCE | ENABLING DEVELOPMENT

IST UTC + 5:30 — India's Official Time Reference

WHAT ARE THE IST RULES 2026?

- A new legal and technical framework to define, maintain and disseminate Indian Standard Time (IST).
- Provides a common, accurate and enforceable national time reference for all sectors.
- Ensures synchronisation of time across government, industry and citizens.
- Brings timekeeping under a robust regulatory and technical system.

KEY PROVISIONS

- Legally enforceable Indian Standard Time
- Authorises **CSIR–NPL** as the national timekeeper
- Standardised time dissemination across telecom, internet, broadcast and critical infrastructure
- Periodical calibration and audit mechanisms
- Defines responsibilities for government and private entities
- Measures for security, redundancy and resilience

WHO MAINTAINS IST?

CSIR-NPL
National Physical Laboratory, New Delhi
वैज्ञानिक सेवा राष्ट्र सेवा

- India's apex institute for timekeeping.
- Maintains IST using advanced atomic clocks.
- Generates and disseminates time signals through multiple channels.
- Works under the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research (CSIR), Ministry of Science & Technology.

CSIR-NPL is India's official source for Indian Standard Time.

HOW IS IST GENERATED?

ATOMIC CLOCKS
Ultra-precise cesium atomic clocks at CSIR-NPL measure time.

↓

UTC COMPARISON
IST is kept in sync with Coordinated Universal Time (UTC) with an offset of +5:30 hours.

↓

DISSEMINATION
Time signals are shared via telecom networks, internet (NTP), broadcast, and dedicated services to government and industry.

UNDERSTANDING THE TIME TERMS

UTC (Coordinated Universal Time)
- Global time standard maintained by BIPM.
- Based on atomic clocks.
- Not affected by time zones.

IST (Indian Standard Time)
- UTC + 5:30 hours (5 hours 30 minutes ahead).
- Single time zone for the entire country.
- No daylight saving time.

ATOMIC CLOCKS
- Use the natural vibration of atoms (usually cesium).
- Extremely accurate (error of less than a second in millions of years).
- Foundation for UTC and IST.

WHY SYNCHRONISED TIME MATTERS?

- **Digital Infrastructure** — Essential for telecom, internet, 5G/6G, cloud services and data centres.
- **Cybersecurity** — Prevents time spoofing; critical for encryption, digital signatures and secure transactions.
- **Financial Systems** — Accurate time is vital for stock markets, banking and digital payments.
- **Transport & Logistics** — Navigation, railways, aviation and shipping depend on precise time.
- **Power Grids** — Synchronisation ensures stable and reliable electricity supply.
- **Governance & Public Services** — Supports e-governance, emergency services and legal processes.
- **Space & Defence** — Critical for satellite operations, navigation (GPS/NavIC) and secure communications.

LEGAL METROLOGY PERSPECTIVE

- Time measurement falls under the Legal Metrology Act, 2009.
- The IST Rules 2026 provide the legal basis for enforcement, compliance and penalties in case of tampering or misuse.
- Ensures uniformity across industries and service providers.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. IST Rules 2026 provide a common and enforceable national time reference.
2. CSIR-NPL maintains IST using atomic clocks.
3. IST = UTC + 5:30 (no daylight saving time).
4. Accurate time is critical for cybersecurity, finance, transport, power and digital India.
5. Strengthens trust, security and resilience in a connected economy.

THE BIGGER PICTURE

- A synchronised India
- A secure digital future
- Stronger economy
- Reliable infrastructure
- Greater national security

ACCURATE TIME CONNECTS PEOPLE POWERS PROGRESS

SAME TIME A STRONGER TOMORROW

INDIA–BELGIUM RELATIONS UPGRADED

Stronger Partnerships for a Shared Prosperity

DEMOCRACIES PARTNERS FOR A BETTER TOMORROW

STRONGER PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE TIES | CLEANER GREENER FUTURE | INNOVATION & TECHNOLOGY | SHARED VALUES A STRONGER WORLD

Grand Place, Brussels (Belgium)

KEY ANNOUNCEMENTS

- India and Belgium agreed to deepen cooperation in trade, defence, clean energy, critical minerals, semiconductors, research and talent mobility.
- **Investment Fast-Track Mechanism** to facilitate and accelerate investments.
- **Goal to double bilateral trade within five years.**
- Enhanced collaboration in education, research, innovation and talent mobility.
- Commitment to a long-term, strategic partnership based on shared democratic values.

AREAS OF COOPERATION

- Trade & Investment
- Defence & Security
- Clean Energy & Climate Action
- Critical Minerals
- Semiconductors & Advanced Manufacturing
- Research, Innovation & Technology
- Education & Talent Mobility
- People-to-People Ties
- Sustainable Development

WHY BELGIUM MATTERS?

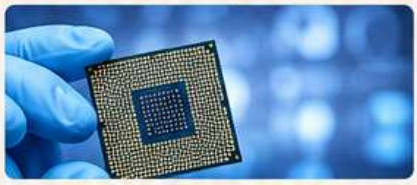
- **Strategic location**
  Gateway to the European Union, hosts EU institutions (EU Commission and EU Council).
- **Economic strength**
  Highly developed economy with strengths in chemicals, pharmaceuticals, engineering, logistics and high-tech industries.
- **Innovation hub**
  Home to world-class research institutions, universities and R&D ecosystem.
- **Key role in global supply chains**
  Important player in semiconductors, pharmaceuticals and critical raw materials.
- **Influence in global governance**
  Active in multilateral forums, supports a rules-based international order.

INDIA–EU RELATIONS CONTEXT

- Belgium is an important partner within the European Union.
- India–EU Strategic Partnership covers trade, connectivity, climate change, clean energy, digital technology and people-to-people ties.
- Belgium often supports closer India–EU economic and political engagement.
- Forthcoming India–EU Free Trade Agreement (FTA) will further strengthen ties.

Stronger India–Belgium ties contribute to a deeper and broader India–EU partnership.

SEMICONDUCTORS



- Belgium is a key player in the global semiconductor supply chain (e.g., advanced materials, equipment, research).
- Cooperation can support India's semiconductor mission through technology, R&D and skilled talent.
- Reduces dependence on limited geographies and strengthens supply-chain resilience.
- Opens opportunities for joint research, manufacturing and innovation.

CRITICAL MINERALS

- Belgium plays an important role in trading and processing critical minerals.
- Cooperation ensures secure, diversified and sustainable supply chains for India's clean energy transition.
- Helps India's green hydrogen, electric vehicles, renewable energy and high-tech manufacturing sectors.
- Aligns with shared goal of building resilient and responsible mineral supply chains.

BILATERAL TRADE

Current trade (2024-25)
~ US$ 13.5 billion (approx.)

Target
Double trade within 5 years

Major items of trade

India's exports
Pharmaceuticals, chemicals, textiles, machinery, agri-products, IT services

India's imports
Diamonds, machinery, chemicals, electronic goods, metals and high-tech products

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Upgradation reflects growing trust and convergence of interests.
2. Opens new opportunities in trade, defence, clean energy, critical minerals and semiconductors.
3. Supports India's economic growth, technological advancement and green transition.
4. Strengthens India–EU partnership and India's global standing.
5. A win-win partnership for a stable, prosperous and sustainable future.

Atomium, Brussels (Symbol of innovation and progress)

PEOPLE | PARTNERSHIP | PROGRESS

STRONGER TODAY
BRIGHTER TOMORROW

SEMICON INDIA 2026

Silicon to Systems: Building the Ecosystem

India's platform to power a self-reliant and globally connected semiconductor ecosystem

TECHNOLOGY
INNOVATION
ATMANIRBHAR BHARAT

Dates	Venue	Edition	Theme
17 – 19 September 2026	New Delhi (India)	5th Edition	Silicon to Systems: Building the Ecosystem

ABOUT SEMICON INDIA

- Flagship event bringing together government, industry, investors, innovators and global partners.
- Showcases opportunities across the semiconductor value chain.
- Platform for policy dialogue, partnerships, technology showcase and investment promotion.
- Positions India as a key player in the global semiconductor ecosystem.

KEY FOCUS AREAS (2026)

- Manufacturing and supply chains
- ATMP/OSAT and design ecosystem
- Emerging technologies (AI, EV, IoT, 5G)
- Global partnerships and investments
- Startup innovation and talent development
- Resilient and secure supply chains
- Sustainability and green semiconductors

ORGANISED BY

Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology
Government of India

semicon india
BUILDING A RESILIENT SEMICONDUCTOR ECOSYSTEM

Towards a Viksit Bharat through Semiconductors

INDIA SEMICONDUCTOR MISSION (ISM)

INDIA SEMICONDUCTOR MISSION
Catalyzing India's Semiconductor Ecosystem

- Launched in 2021 under MeitY.
- Objective: Develop a vibrant semiconductor and display manufacturing ecosystem in India.
- Financial support for fabs, ATMP/OSAT units, design infrastructure, and R&D.
- Focus on creating a self-reliant, innovation-driven and globally competitive semiconductor sector.
- Total outlay: ~₹76,000 crore.

SEMICON 2.0 (NEXT PHASE)

- Builds on the momentum of ISM.
- Focus on larger, more advanced fabs.
- Greater support for design, R&D and compound semiconductors (SiC, GaN).
- Incentives for equipment & materials manufacturing.
- Skilling and talent development at scale.
- Stronger integration with global supply chains.
- Aims to position India as a global semiconductor hub.

KEY SEGMENTS OF THE VALUE CHAIN

Fab (Wafer Fabrication)	ATMP/OSAT (Assembly, Testing, Marking & Packaging)	Design
Manufactures semiconductor wafers (front-end processes).	Packages and tests chips (back-end processes).	Chip design, IP cores and EDA tools.

Complete ecosystem: Materials + Equipment + Design + Manufacturing + Packaging + Testing + End-use industries

SUPPLY-CHAIN SECURITY

- Reduces dependence on a single country for critical chips.
- Diversifies sources of raw materials, equipment and technology.
- Builds domestic manufacturing and trusted supply chains.
- Enhances resilience against geopolitical shocks and disruptions.

CHINA–US COMPETITION: IMPLICATIONS

China

- Dominates global chip manufacturing (high share in mature nodes).
- Strong control over critical minerals and supply chains.
- US export restrictions on advanced chips and equipment.
- India seeks to reduce over-dependence on China.

United States

- Leads in advanced chip design, technology and equipment.
- Imposes export controls to limit China's access to high-end chips.
- Seeks trusted partners to diversify supply chains ("China+1").
- India is seen as a key partner in building resilient supply chains.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR INDIA?

- Supports Atmanirbhar Bharat and economic growth.
- Generates high-skilled jobs.
- Enables domestic manufacturing in strategic sectors (electronics, defence, automotive, telecom, AI).
- Strengthens technological sovereignty and national security.
- Positions India in the evolving global semiconductor value chain.

FROM CHIPS TO A STRONGER INDIA

SELF-RELIANCE | INNOVATION | GLOBAL PARTNERSHIP | SUSTAINABLE GROWTH

SEMICONDUCTORS
POWER
PEOPLE
PROSPERITY

A STRONGER TECH INDIA
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

MARINE FISHERIES & INDIA'S BLUE ECONOMY

Healthy Oceans, Prosperous People, Stronger India

FOOD NUTRITION | MILLIONS OF LIVELIHOODS | EXPORT EARNINGS | SUSTAINABLE OCEAN GROWTH

INDIA'S MARINE RESOURCES

India has a long coastline of **7,517 km** with 9 coastal states and 4 Union Territories

MARINE FISHERIES AT A GLANCE

4.3 million tonnes
Marine fish production (2023–24, approx.)

~ 4 million
People depend on marine fisheries (fishers, fish farmers, workers, allied activities)

~ ₹60,000+ crore
Export earnings from marine products (2023–24)

Key to nutrition
Provides high-quality protein, essential omega-3 fatty acids and micronutrients

Major species
Tuna, shrimp, sardine, mackerel, seer fish, pomfret, squid, cuttlefish, lobster, crab etc.

WHAT IS BLUE ECONOMY?

Sustainable use of ocean resources for economic growth, improved livelihoods and ocean ecosystem health.

Fisheries & Aquaculture | Maritime Transport & Ports | Offshore Energy (oil, gas, renewables) | Coastal Tourism

Marine Biodiversity | Blue Technology & Ocean Innovation | Seabed Minerals (Polymetallic nodules, polymetallic sulphides, etc.)

Blue Economy = Economic Growth + Healthy Oceans + Resilient Coastal Communities

PM MATSYA SAMPADA YOJANA (PMMSY)

(2020–21 to 2024–25)

Objective: Sustainable and responsible development of fisheries sector.

Total Investment: ~ ₹20,050 crore
(Central share ~ ₹9,407 crore)

Key Components:

- Enhancing fish production and productivity
- Infrastructure (fishing harbours, landing centres, cold chain)
- Fisheries value chain and marketing
- Aquaculture development
- Fishers' welfare and social security
- Monitoring, control and surveillance (against IUU fishing)

SUSTAINABLE FISHING & CONSERVATION

Prevent overfishing
Follow science-based catch limits and seasonal bans (e.g., breeding season).

Reduce bycatch
Use selective and eco-friendly fishing gear.

Protect marine ecosystems
Conserve coral reefs, mangroves, seagrass and breeding grounds.

Combat IUU fishing
Strengthen monitoring, control and surveillance (MCS) using technology (VMS, AIS, drones).

Promote responsible aquaculture
Adopt low-impact, climate-resilient and sustainable practices.

UNCLOS & INDIA

- UNCLOS (1982) is the legal framework governing oceans and their resources.
- Defines maritime zones:
  - Territorial Sea – up to 12 nm
  - Contiguous Zone – up to 24 nm
  - **Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) – up to 200 nm**
  - Continental Shelf – beyond 200 nm (up to 350 nm in some cases)
- Gives sovereign rights over resource exploration and exploitation in the EEZ and continental shelf.
- India is a party to UNCLOS and actively participates in its institutions (e.g., ISA – International Seabed Authority).

UNCLOS enables India to harness its ocean wealth **while ensuring responsible and sustainable use.**

CHALLENGES

- Overfishing and declining fish stocks
- Climate change (ocean warming, acidification)
- Marine pollution (plastic, oil spills, ghost nets)
- IUU fishing by foreign vessels
- Habitat loss (mangroves, coral reefs)
- Livelihood vulnerability of coastal communities
- Need for better data, research and enforcement

OPPORTUNITIES

- Rising global demand for seafood
- Value addition and export diversification
- Deep-sea fishing and under-exploited resources (e.g., tuna)
- Mariculture and seaweed cultivation
- Ocean-based renewable energy (offshore wind, tidal)
- Blue biotechnology and pharmaceuticals
- Coastal and island tourism
- Employment generation and women's participation

WAY FORWARD

- Implement science-based fisheries management
- Strengthen MCS and curb IUU fishing
- Invest in sustainable aquaculture and eco-friendly infrastructure
- Empower fishers with technology, credit and social security
- Enhance research in marine biodiversity and climate resilience
- Regional and global cooperation for healthy oceans
- Mainstream Blue Economy in national growth strategy

"Healthy Oceans Today for Prosperous Generations Tomorrow"

VIKSIT BHARAT 2047

SUSTAINABLE RESOURCES | RESILIENT COMMUNITIES | THRIVING ECONOMY | CLEANER OCEANS

AI VS COPYRIGHT LAW

Innovation, Intellectual Property and a Fair Future

How do we balance the promise of generative AI with the rights of creators?

CREATIVITY FUELS HUMAN PROGRESS. LET IT THRIVE IN THE AI ERA.

GS-II / GS-III
UPSC CURRENT AFFAIRS

THE ISSUE

- Generative AI models are trained on massive amounts of data, often including copyrighted material (text, images, music, etc.).
- Creators and publishers allege unauthorised use of their works.
- AI companies argue it is necessary for innovation and may be covered under exceptions like fair dealing (fair use).
- The debate is about how to balance creators' rights with technological progress.

KEY STAKEHOLDERS

Creators
(authors, artists, musicians, filmmakers, publishers)
Seek recognition, consent and fair compensation.

AI companies
Need large datasets to train models; argue for flexibility and legal clarity.

Users / Public
Access to innovative and affordable AI products.

Governments & Regulators
Balance innovation, IP rights and public interest.

RELEVANT LEGAL FRAMEWORK

Copyright Act, 1957 (India)

- Protects original literary, dramatic, musical and artistic works, etc.
- Rights include reproduction, communication to the public, adaptation and translation.
- Duration: Generally life of author + 60 years.

Key Provisions / Concepts

- **Section 14** – exclusive rights of copyright owner.
- **Section 51** – what constitutes infringement.
- **Section 52** – exceptions (fair dealing for research, private use, criticism, review, reporting of current events, etc.).
- **Section 57** – moral rights (right to attribution, integrity).

FAIR DEALING IN THE AI CONTEXT

AI training may be argued as:

- "Fair dealing" for research or non-commercial purposes.
- "Transformative use" (creates new outputs, not a substitute).

- Concerns:
  - Large-scale, commercial use may go beyond fair dealing.
  - Exact reproduction or close outputs can harm the market for original works.

Whether AI training is 'fair dealing' is a key legal question, and courts worldwide are examining it.

KEY CONCERNS

- Unauthorised use of copyrighted works for training data.
- Loss of income for creators and industries (music, publishing, media).
- Risk of plagiarism and generation of similar/competing works.
- Lack of transparency about training data.
- Bias and misuse of copyrighted or sensitive content.
- Impact on cultural diversity and traditional knowledge.

GLOBAL DEVELOPMENTS

United States
- Courts examining 'fair use' in AI training (e.g., lawsuits by authors, news organisations, artists).
- No specific AI copyright law yet.

European Union
- EU AI Act (2024) requires transparency about training data and respect for copyright.
- Text and Data Mining (TDM) exceptions with opt-out for rightsholders.

United Kingdom
- Consultations on copyright and AI.
- Proposes a more flexible regime with transparency requirements.

China
- Guidelines recognise copyright protection, with some allowances for training under specific conditions.

INDIA'S APPROACH

- No specific AI law yet; existing Copyright Act, 1957 applies.
- Government and expert bodies are examining the issue (consultations, committee discussions).
- Focus areas:
  - Need for transparency in training data.
  - Possible licensing or collective management systems.
  - Protection of creators' rights while enabling innovation and AI for public good.
- Also linked to India's digital economy, AI strategy and creative industry growth.

India needs a balanced, future-ready framework that protects creators, promotes innovation and leverages AI for inclusive growth.

POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

Licensing models
Structured access to copyrighted content.

Collective management organisations
Pooling of rights and revenue sharing.

Transparency requirements
Disclosure of training data sources.

Compensation mechanisms
Revenue sharing or data compensation funds.

Clear guidelines on fair dealing
Define permissible uses for AI training.

Promote open datasets
Publicly available, licensed content.

IMPLICATIONS FOR UPSC

GS-II (Polity & Governance)

- Intellectual property rights
- Regulation of emerging technologies
- Role of government in balancing innovation and rights

GS-III (Science & Technology)

- AI and its applications
- Impact on economy and creative industries
- Ethical and legal challenges in technology

Essay / Ethics / Interdisciplinary

- Innovation vs. rights
- Technology and human values
- Inclusive growth in the digital age

KEY TAKEAWAYS

1. Generative AI has intensified the debate on copyright, with no easy answers.
2. Copyright Act, 1957 provides protection, but its application to AI training is evolving.
3. Global approaches vary — from flexible exceptions to stricter transparency norms.
4. India needs a balanced framework that ensures creator compensation, encourages innovation and aligns with global best practices.
5. The issue has far-reaching implications for the creative economy, digital rights and the future of AI governance.

SUPPORT CREATIVITY. ENABLE INNOVATION. BUILD A FAIR AI FUTURE.

PEOPLE IDEAS PROGRESS

ClearExams
-YOUR PATH TO SUCCESS-

STAY INFORMED STAY AHEAD

DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS

KEY NEWS | DEEPER INSIGHTS | EXAM FOCUS

5 SEPTEMBER 2026

DAILY CURRENT AFFAIRS FOR UPSC & OTHER COMPETITIVE EXAMS

6 IMPORTANT TOPICS TODAY — 5 SEPTEMBER 2026

1 INDIA'S FOREX RESERVES HIT A FRESH RECORD

RBI data show foreign-exchange reserves reach **$740.8 billion** for the week ended August 28.

GS-III | ECONOMY

2 RBI MOVES TO ABSORB RECORD LIQUIDITY

₹7-trillion, 30-day VRRR auction announced against a banking-system liquidity surplus of around **₹10.3** trillion.

GS-III | ECONOMY

3 INDIA'S STRONG GDP GROWTH SPARKS A DEBATE

High growth numbers, but questions remain on employment and investment.

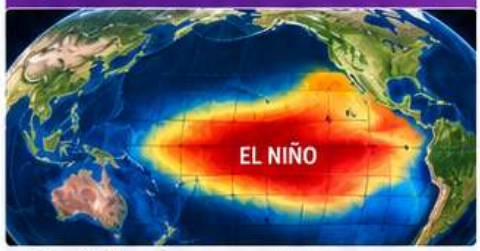
GS-III | ECONOMY

4 BELOW-NORMAL SEPTEMBER RAINFALL RAISES CROP CONCERNS

Uneven monsoon and below-normal September rainfall may affect kharif output and food inflation.

GS-I | GEOGRAPHY | GS-III

5 SUPER EL NIÑO RISK



Possibility of an unusually strong El Niño event and its wide-ranging impacts on weather and the Indian monsoon.

GS-I | GEOGRAPHY | GS-III

6 NASA's NANCY GRACE ROMAN SPACE TELESCOPE

A next-generation observatory to study dark energy, dark matter, exoplanets and more.

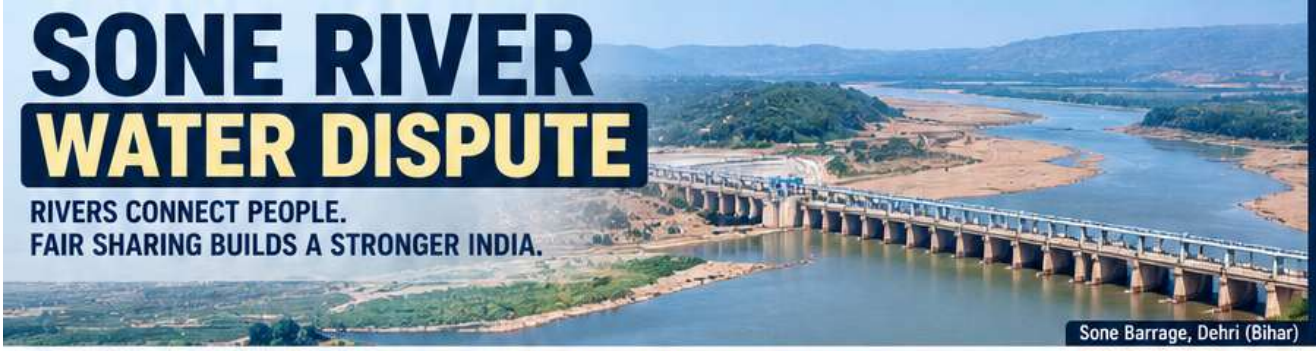
GS-III | SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

CLEAN FACTS | CONCEPT CLARITY | EXAM ORIENTATION | A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

CURRENT AFFAIRS TODAY
A STRONGER YOU TOMORROW

SONE RIVER WATER DISPUTE

RIVERS CONNECT PEOPLE.
FAIR SHARING BUILDS A STRONGER INDIA.


Sone Barrage, Dehri (Bihar)

A DISPUTE OVER WATER, A SHARED RESPONSIBILITY.

COOPERATIVE FEDERALISM FOR A WATER SECURE INDIA

ABOUT THE SONE (SON) RIVER

- **Also known as:** Son River (Sone)
- **Origin:** Amarkantak Plateau, Maikal Hills (Madhya Pradesh)
- **Length:** ~784 km
- **Major tributaries:** Rihand, North Koel, Johilla, Gopad, Kanhar
- **Flows through:** Madhya Pradesh → Uttar Pradesh → Bihar
- **Confluence:** Joins the Ganga near Patna (Bihar)
- **Part of:** Ganga river basin
- **Importance:** Irrigation, drinking water, hydropower, and supports agriculture in the eastern Indo-Gangetic plains.

COURSE OF THE SONE RIVER

WHY IS THERE A DISPUTE?

- **Sharing of water**
  Differing state interests on allocation for irrigation, power and drinking water.
- **Upstream vs downstream concerns**
  Upstream projects may reduce water availability downstream.
- **Irrigation demands**
  High demand for irrigation in water-scarce regions (especially during lean season).
- **Multipurpose projects**
  Proposals for dams and barrages (e.g., Kanhar, Bansagar, etc.) have raised concerns.
- **Lack of a final settlement**
  Demands for a tribunal and formal allocation persist.

KEY PROJECTS ON THE SONE RIVER

Project	Location	Purpose	Key points
Indrapuri Barrage	Dehri (Bihar)	Irrigation, water supply, power	Major existing structure (commissioned in 1960s).
Bansagar Project	Madhya Pradesh (U.P.–MP border)	Irrigation, power	Multipurpose project; water sharing concerns.
North Koel Project	Jharkhand	Irrigation	Proposed; linked to inter-state discussions (with Koel and Son basins).
Kanhar Project	Madhya Pradesh	Irrigation	Proposed; part of Madhya Pradesh's plans.
Rihand Dam	U.P. (on tributary)	Irrigation, hydropower	On major tributary of Son.

LEGAL AND INSTITUTIONAL FRAMEWORK

Article 262 of the Constitution
- Empowers Parliament to provide for adjudication of inter-state river water disputes.
- Parliament can also bar the jurisdiction of the Supreme Court in such disputes.

Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956
- Provides for the constitution of a tribunal to adjudicate disputes.
- Tribunal's decision is final and binding on the parties.

Inter-State River Water Disputes (Amendment) Act, 2002
- Streamlined the process for constitution of tribunals.
- Provides for a permanent tribunal mechanism (now through the Inter-State River Water Disputes Tribunal).

SONE RIVER DISPUTE: KEY STAKEHOLDERS

Madhya Pradesh
- Proposes projects for irrigation and power.
- Seeks greater share for development needs.

Uttar Pradesh
- Depends on water for irrigation in eastern U.P.
- Concerns over upstream diversions.

Bihar
- Relies on downstream flows.
- Concerns over reduced water availability due to upstream projects.

Need for consultation, data sharing and mutually acceptable agreements.

SIGNIFICANCE OF RESOLVING THE DISPUTE

- Improved agricultural productivity and food security
- Drinking water security for millions
- Greater power generation potential
- Balanced regional development
- Strengthens cooperative federalism
- Supports climate resilience and sustainable water management

CHALLENGES

- Divergent state interests
- Variable and seasonal river flows
- Impact of climate change
- Lack of real-time data sharing
- Political sensitivities
- Delays in constituting tribunals and implementing decisions

THE WAY FORWARD

- Early constitution of a tribunal (if needed)
- Data-driven and transparent decision-making
- Basin-level planning and integrated water resource management
- Focus on equitable and sustainable use
- Strengthen inter-state consultation mechanisms
- Align with the National Water Policy, 2012 and climate adaptation strategies

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

- **GS-II:** Inter-state relations, federalism, dispute resolution mechanisms, role of tribunals, governance.
- **GS-I:** River systems of India, Ganga basin, physical geography.
- **GS-III:** Water resource management, irrigation, sustainable development.
- **Essay:** Cooperative federalism and equitable sharing of natural resources.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The Sone River is a vital tributary of the Ganga.
- Disputes arise due to competing demands for water among Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.
- Article 262 and the Inter-State River Water Disputes Act, 1956 provide the legal framework.
- A cooperative, data-driven and sustainable approach is essential for long-term water security and regional harmony.

WATER SHARED WISELY FUELS A PROSPEROUS TOMORROW

NASA's NANCY GRACE ROMAN SPACE TELESCOPE

A NEW EYE ON THE UNIVERSE

NASA's Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope (Roman Telescope) will explore the cosmos, from dark energy and dark matter to exoplanets, using a wide field of view and advanced instruments.

SAME UNIVERSE. BIGGER QUESTIONS. BOLDER ANSWERS.

Wider. Deeper. More to Discover.
Mapping the Universe. Finding New Worlds.

WIDE VIEW. DEEP INSIGHTS. BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

KEY FACTS

Agency
NASA

Launch (planned)
May 2027

Launch vehicle
SpaceX Falcon Heavy

Orbit
L2 (Sun–Earth Lagrange Point)

Mission duration
At least 5 years (goal: 10 years)

Primary goal
Wide-field observations to study dark energy, dark matter, exoplanets and the infrared universe

WHO WAS NANCY GRACE ROMAN?

Nancy Grace Roman (1925–2018)

- Pioneering astronomer and NASA's first Chief of Astronomy (1960–1979)
- Played a key role in the Hubble Space Telescope
- Known as the "Mother of Hubble"
- Advocated for large space missions and greater participation of women in science

"The future of astronomy is in space."
– Nancy Grace Roman

MAIN INSTRUMENTS

Wide Field Instrument (WFI)

- 18 detectors, ultra-wide field of view
- 100 times larger area than Hubble's imaging
- Hiph-resolution imaging and slitless spectroscopy
- Will survey billions of galaxies

Coronagraph Instrument (CGI)

- Blocks starlight to detect faint planets
- Will directly image exoplanets
- Demonstrates advanced wavefront-control technology

WHAT WILL ROMAN STUDY?

Dark Energy
Map the large-scale structure of the universe to understand the nature of dark energy and the universe's accelerating expansion.

Dark Matter
Study the distribution of dark matter through gravitational effects (weak lensing).

Exoplanets
Directly image exoplanets and study their atmospheres using the coronagraph.

Gravitational Microlensing
Detect exoplanets, including low-mass and distant planets, using microlensing (gravitational lensing by a foreground star).

HOW IT WILL WORK

1. **Wide-field survey**
   Capture images of large areas of the sky in infrared light.
2. **Detect faint signals**
   Use sensitive instruments to observe distant galaxies, weak gravitational lensing and exoplanets.
3. **Data analysis**
   Map billions of galaxies and detect tiny changes in light caused by dark matter and dark energy.
4. **New discoveries**
   Provide insights into the origins, evolution and future of the universe.

COMPARISON WITH OTHER TELESCOPES

Feature	Hubble	James Webb (JWST)	Roman
Launch year	1990	2021	2027 (planned)
Primary focus	General astronomy	Early universe, IR observations	Wide-field survey, dark energy, exoplanets
Wavelength range	Visible, UV, near-IR	Infrared (0.6 – 28 µm)	Near-IR (0.48 – 2.3 µm)
Field of view	Narrow (~10 arcmin)	Narrow (~9.7 arcmin)	Very wide (~0.28 deg²; ~100× Hubble)
Key strength	High-resolution imaging	Deep infrared imaging	Wide-field imaging, cosmic surveys, exoplanet imaging

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

- Will survey billions of galaxies, much larger than previous missions.
- Helps answer fundamental questions about the nature of dark energy and dark matter.
- Will expand our search for exoplanets, including Earth-like worlds.
- Complements Hubble and JWST, providing a wider and deeper view of the universe.

EXPECTED OUTCOMES

- A detailed map of the universe and its evolution
- Better understanding of dark energy and dark matter
- Discovery and characterisation of thousands of exoplanets
- New insights into galaxy formation, stellar populations and cosmic structure

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

GS-III: Science & Technology

- Space technology and missions
- Astronomy and astrophysics
- Applications of space research

Prelims: Important facts (agency, instruments, L2, objectives, etc.)

Mains: Significance for scientific advancement, human knowledge and international space collaboration

Also linked to: International cooperation (in NASA), role of space technology in sustainable development

FROM NEW WORLDS TO BIGGER ANSWERS

THE ROMAN TELESCOPE WILL HELP US SEE FARTHER, UNDERSTAND DEEPER.

"By exploring the universe, we also discover our place in it."

SCIENCE TODAY
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

SUPER EL NIÑO RISK

A STRONGER OCEAN WARMING, BIGGER IMPACTS

Meteorological agencies are warning of the possibility of an unusually strong El Niño event, with wide-ranging implications for global weather, the Indian monsoon, agriculture, marine ecosystems and the world economy.

OCEAN CHANGES SHAPE OUR WEATHER

UNDERSTAND
PREPARE
BUILD RESILIENCE

WHAT IS EL NIÑO?

- El Niño is the warm phase of ENSO (El Niño–Southern Oscillation).
- It refers to the abnormal warming of sea surface temperatures (SST) in the central and eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean.
- Occurs once every 2–7 years, usually lasting 9–12 months.
- Can range from weak to very strong; "Super El Niño" refers to an unusually intense event (e.g., 1982–83, 1997–98, 2015–16).

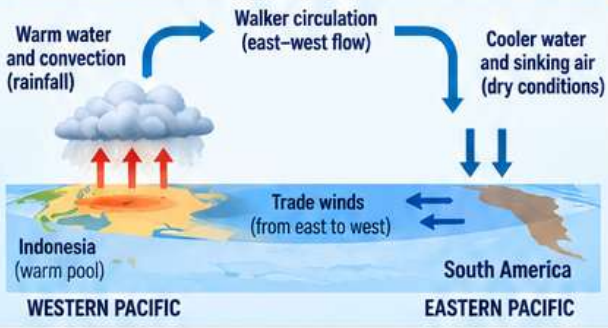
WHAT IS LA NIÑA?

- La Niña is the cool phase of ENSO.
- Characterised by below-normal SST in the central and eastern Pacific.
- Associated with stronger trade winds and enhanced upwelling of cold water.
- Often leads to above-normal rainfall in many parts of the world, including India (generally).

ENSO CYCLE

- ENSO is a natural climate phenomenon in the tropical Pacific Ocean.
- It has two opposite phases — El Niño (warm) and La Niña (cool), and a neutral phase.
- Driven by changes in sea surface temperatures, trade winds and ocean–atmosphere interactions.
- Monitored using Oceanic Niño Index (ONI) (3-month average SST anomaly in Niño 3.4 region).

THE WALKER CIRCULATION (NORMAL CONDITIONS)

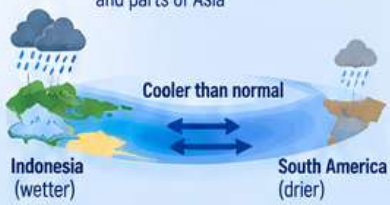


DURING EL NIÑO

Weaker trade winds
Movement of warm water towards central and eastern Pacific
Reduced upwelling
Suppressed rainfall over Indonesia and parts of Asia

DURING LA NIÑA

Stronger trade winds
Enhanced upwelling of cold water
Increased rainfall over Indonesia and parts of Asia



CLASSIFICATION (BASED ON ONI)

Category	ONI (°C)
La Niña (weak)	-0.5 to -0.9
La Niña (moderate)	-1.0 to -1.4
La Niña (strong)	≤ -1.5
Neutral	-0.4 to +0.4
El Niño (weak)	+0.5 to +0.9
El Niño (moderate)	+1.0 to +1.4
El Niño (strong)	+1.5 to +1.9
Super El Niño	**≥ +2.0**

GLOBAL IMPACTS OF A SUPER EL NIÑO

Higher global temperatures
Contributes to the warmest years on record.

Changed rainfall patterns
Droughts in some regions, floods in others.

More extreme weather
Higher frequency and intensity of heatwaves, heavy rainfall and tropical cyclones.

Food security risks
Lower crop yields in drought-affected regions.

Marine ecosystem stress
Coral bleaching, disruption of fisheries.

Economic impacts
Agriculture, fisheries, energy and global trade can be affected.

IMPACT ON INDIA

Weaker southwest monsoon
Higher chance of below-normal rainfall (though not always).

Risk to kharif crops
Particularly rainfed agriculture (rice, pulses, oilseeds).

Higher temperatures
More heatwaves and prolonged dry spells.

Lower reservoir levels
Can affect irrigation and drinking water supply.

Higher food inflation
Reduced domestic production may increase food prices.

May influence tropical cyclones
Shifts in cyclone frequency and tracks in the Indian Ocean region.

HISTORICAL SUPER EL NIÑO EVENTS

Year	Global Impact	Impact on India
1982–83	High global temperatures, widespread droughts	Severe monsoon deficit, drought
1997–98	Major climate disruptions	Weak monsoon, lower agricultural output
2015–16	Warmest year on record (at that time)	Below-normal monsoon, drought in many regions

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ☑ El Niño and La Niña are opposite phases of ENSO.
- ☑ Super El Niño (ONI ≥ +2.0°C) is rare but has major global impacts.
- ☑ It can weaken the Indian monsoon and affect agriculture, water availability and food prices.
- ☑ It influences marine ecosystems and extreme weather events.
- ☑ Continuous monitoring and early warning systems are essential for climate resilience.

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

- **GS-I: Geography** – ENSO, Walker circulation, ocean–atmosphere interactions, climatic phenomena
- **GS-III: Agriculture** – impact on crops, food security, irrigation, disaster management
- **GS-III: Environment** – marine ecosystems, coral reefs, climate change, extreme weather
- **GS-III: Indian Economy** – food inflation, agriculture, climate risks, resilient infrastructure

Also useful for: Essays (climate change & food security), Disaster management, Sustainable development

BELOW-NORMAL SEPTEMBER RAINFALL RAISES CROP CONCERNS

Rainfall patterns are becoming crucial for agricultural output after an uneven monsoon, making the link between the southwest monsoon, kharif crops and food inflation important.

Good monsoon supports farm output, rural incomes and controls food inflation. Deficient rainfall can reduce crop yields, strain reservoirs and increase food prices.

ALL-INDIA RAINFALL STATUS

(June – September 2026, up to early September)

Cumulative rainfall is below normal, with September showing a deficit.

SEPTEMBER RAINFALL BELOW NORMAL

Period	Actual (mm)	Normal (mm)	% Departure
June	102.3	96.1	+6%
July	285.4	290.1	-2%
August	248.7	264.9	-6%
September (upto 3 Sep)	28.4	86.7	-67%
Season (Jun–Sep)	**666.7**	**741.8**	-10%

Note: Figures are illustrative and based on IMD updates (as of early September 2026).

HOW THE SOUTHWEST MONSOON WORKS

1. **Land–sea heating contrast** – Indian land heats faster than ocean in summer, creating low pressure over land and high pressure over ocean.
2. **Moisture-laden winds** – Southwest monsoon winds from the Indian Ocean bring moisture towards India.
3. **Orographic uplift** – Winds rise over Western Ghats, Himalayas and other ranges, causing rain.
4. **Branching** – Arabian Sea branch and Bay of Bengal branch cover different parts of India.
5. **Retreat** – Monsoon withdraws from northwest India by September.

FACTORS AFFECTING MONSOON RAINFALL

ENSO (El Niño/La Niña)
- El Niño → weaker monsoon, below-normal rainfall
- La Niña → stronger monsoon, above-normal rainfall

Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD)
- Positive IOD → supports better monsoon rainfall
- Negative IOD → can weaken monsoon

Snow cover over Himalayas
Less snow cover can weaken the monsoon.

Land surface and heat waves
Higher pre-monsoon heat can strengthen monsoon circulation (to an extent).

Cyclonic systems
Monsoon depressions and low-pressure systems enhance rainfall.

Climate change
Increasing variability, extreme rainfall events and longer dry spells.

MONSOON AND KHARIF CROPS

Kharif crops depend heavily on timely and well-distributed rainfall.

RICE	MAIZE	PULSES (tur, urad, moong)	OILSEEDS (soybean, groundnut)	COTTON
High dependence on monsoon	Moderate dependence	Sensitive to dry spells	Affected by rainfall distribution	Needs adequate but well-spread rainfall

RESERVOIR STORAGE STATUS

Uneven monsoon has led to lower reservoir levels in some regions.

~70%
of total reservoir capacity
(as of early September 2026)

Lower storage may affect irrigation and rabi sowing if the deficit persists.

IMPACT ON AGRICULTURE AND FOOD INFLATION

- Lower crop yields if rainfall deficit continues.
- Reduced farm incomes, especially for rainfed areas.
- Tighter supply of foodgrains, pulses and oilseeds.
- Upward pressure on food inflation (e.g., cereals, vegetables, pulses).
- Greater need for buffer stock releases and import management.

RECENT TRENDS IN FOOD INFLATION

Food inflation remains sensitive to monsoon performance.

A prolonged rainfall deficit can push food inflation higher, affecting overall inflation and household welfare.

KEY RISKS TO WATCH

- Continued below-normal September rainfall
- Impact on kharif sowing and yields
- Decline in reservoir levels
- Spike in food prices (cereals, pulses, vegetables, edible oils)
- Possibility of El Niño strengthening
- Higher vulnerability of rainfed regions and small farmers

POLICY RESPONSE OPTIONS

- Accelerate irrigation support and micro-irrigation schemes
- Ensure adequate buffer stocks (FCI)
- Calibrated imports to manage prices if needed
- Crop insurance and direct income support
- Invest in climate-resilient agriculture and drought-tolerant varieties
- Strengthen weather forecasting and advisories for farmers

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

- **GS-I: Indian Geography** – Monsoon mechanism, ENSO, IOD, climatic factors
- **GS-III: Agriculture** – Cropping patterns, food security, irrigation, reservoir management
- **GS-III: Indian Economy** – Food inflation and its impact, government response
- **GS-III: Environment & Climate Change** – Increasing variability and extreme events

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- September rainfall is below normal, raising crop concerns.
- Monsoon performance directly affects kharif output and food inflation.
- ENSO, IOD and other factors influence monsoon strength.
- Need for climate-resilient agriculture and effective policy response.

STABLE MONSOON
STRONG AGRICULTURE
FOOD SECURITY
PROSPEROUS INDIA

INDIA'S STRONG GDP GROWTH
SPARKS A MEASUREMENT AND DEVELOPMENT DEBATE

High growth numbers, but are jobs and investment keeping pace?

India's GDP growth remains strong, yet questions are being raised on whether the headline numbers are translating into sufficient employment, private investment and inclusive development.

HIGH GROWTH. BIGGER OPPORTUNITIES. INCLUSIVE DEVELOPMENT REMAINS THE GOAL.

SUSTAINABLE GROWTH FOR A DEVELOPED INDIA

LATEST GDP GROWTH

India's real GDP grew by

7.8%

in FY 2025–26

(as per latest official estimates)

Among the fastest-growing major economies in the world.

BUT KEY QUESTIONS REMAIN

- Is enough quality employment being created?
- Is private investment reviving strongly?
- Are the benefits of growth reaching all sections of society?
- Is the growth path sustainable and inclusive?

INDIA IN GLOBAL CONTEXT

Real GDP Growth (Latest available, %)

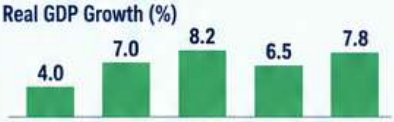
India continues to be one of the fastest-growing major economies.

GDP vs GVA — WHAT'S THE DIFFERENCE?

Aspect	GDP (Gross Domestic Product)	GVA (Gross Value Added)
Meaning	Total value of final goods and services produced in an economy.	Value added at each stage of production (output minus intermediate consumption).
Measurement approach	Product approach, income approach, or expenditure approach.	Sum of value added across sectors (agriculture, industry, services).
Includes	Adds net indirect taxes (subsidies subtracted).	Does not include indirect taxes; focuses on sectoral value addition.
Relationship	GDP = GVA + (Net indirect taxes)	
Use	Overall size of the economy.	Understand sectoral contribution to growth.

GROWTH, EMPLOYMENT AND INVESTMENT TRENDS

Real GDP Growth (%)



Unemployment Rate (%)

(PLFS, 15+ years, usual status)

Gross Fixed Capital Formation (in % of GDP)

WHY THE DEBATE?

- Employment not keeping pace with output growth.
- Private investment remains below pre-pandemic levels.
- Consumption is strong, but dominated by government spending in recent years.
- Concerns over income and regional inequalities.
- Need to translate growth into human development outcomes (health, education, skilling).

FACTORS BEHIND STRONG GDP GROWTH

- Robust services sector (finance, IT, communications)
- Higher public capital expenditure on infrastructure
- Resilient domestic consumption
- Strong exports in key sectors (pharma, electronics, engineering)
- Macroeconomic stability and structural reforms

CHALLENGES AND CONCERNS

- Job creation is less than expected, especially in formal manufacturing.
- Private investment is subdued due to global uncertainty and domestic demand-supply gaps.
- Quality of jobs and low female labour force participation.
- Uneven regional development across states.
- Risk of jobless growth if the manufacturing sector does not expand sufficiently.

THE WAY FORWARD

- Revive private investment through stable policies, ease of doing business and lower regulatory uncertainty.
- Focus on labour-intensive manufacturing and MSMEs.
- Invest in skilling, education and health to improve productivity.
- Promote inclusive growth with regional balance.
- Leverage global opportunities while building domestic resilience.

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

GS-III: Indian Economy

- Measurement of national income (GDP, GVA)
- Investment, employment and inclusive growth
- Issues related to structural transformation and jobless growth
- Policies for sustainable and balanced development

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- ✓ India's GDP growth remains strong.
- ✓ Debate exists on whether growth is translating into adequate employment and investment.
- ✓ Need to focus on quality, inclusive and sustainable growth.
- ✓ Both GDP and GVA are important for understanding economic performance.

> **Growth is meaningful only when it creates opportunities for all.**

Towards a Developed and Inclusive India

RBI MOVES TO ABSORB RECORD BANKING LIQUIDITY

RBI announces ₹7 trillion, 30-day Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR) auction with early-redemption facility

Move comes against a banking-system liquidity surplus of around ₹10.3 trillion.

STABLE LIQUIDITY STRONGER ECONOMY

PRUDENT POLICY FOR A RESILIENT INDIA

KEY NUMBERS

₹7 trillion
VRRR auction size (30-day tenor)

₹10.3 trillion
Banking-system liquidity surplus (approx.)

30 days
Tenor of VRRR

Early exit
Early-redemption facility announced

> "The operation aims to absorb surplus liquidity and ensure orderly conditions in the money market."
>
> — Reserve Bank of India

WHY IS BANKING-SYSTEM LIQUIDITY HIGH?

- High government spending (capex and revenue outlay)
- RBI's dividend transfer to the government
- Higher currency in circulation (e.g., festive demand)
- Moderate credit demand
- Capital inflows and other durable liquidity sources

WHAT IS VRRR?

Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR)

- A monetary policy tool used by RBI to absorb short-term surplus liquidity from the banking system.
- Banks park their surplus funds with RBI at a variable interest rate (determined through auction).
- Funds are withdrawn from the system for a specified period (here 30 days).
- This auction has an early-redemption facility, allowing banks to exit before maturity if needed.

REPO vs REVERSE REPO vs VRRR

Feature	Repo	Reverse Repo	VRRR
Who borrows?	Banks borrow from RBI	Banks lend to RBI	Banks lend to RBI (auction)
Purpose	Injects liquidity	Absorbs liquidity	Absorbs large surplus liquidity
Rate	Fixed (repo rate)	Fixed (reverse repo rate)	**Variable** (auction-based)
Tenor	Usually overnight/short	Usually overnight/short	Specified (30 days in this case)
Flexibility	Regular tool	Regular tool	Used for large, transient liquidity
Current use	Not applicable	Limited use now	**₹7 trillion, 30-day VRRR with early exit**

RBI'S LIQUIDITY MANAGEMENT TOOLS

- **Repo and Reverse Repo** — Adjusts short-term liquidity and policy rates
- **VRRR / Variable Rate Repo** — Fine-tunes liquidity for longer/variable tenors
- **OMOs (Open Market Operations)** — Buy/sell government securities
- **MSF (Marginal Standing Facility)** — Provides overnight liquidity at a penal rate
- **Standing Deposit Facility (SDF)** — Absorbs surplus liquidity (replaced fixed reverse repo)
- **CRR / SLR** — Structural liquidity management tools
- **FX operations** — Manage rupee liquidity through dollar buying/selling

IMPACT OF THIS MOVE

- Helps keep short-term interest rates aligned with the policy stance
- Prevents excessive liquidity from pushing down money-market rates
- Maintains financial stability and orderly market functioning
- Supports monetary policy transmission
- Provides flexibility with early exit option

WHY IT MATTERS?

1. Ensures effective control over system liquidity.
2. Keeps short-term interest rates close to the policy corridor.
3. Helps anchor inflation by supporting monetary policy transmission.
4. Prevents asset price distortions due to excess liquidity.
5. Signals RBI's proactive and flexible liquidity management.

KEY TAKEAWAYS FOR UPSC

- ✅ VRRR is used to absorb surplus liquidity from the banking system.
- ✅ It allows RBI to manage short-term liquidity without changing the policy rate.
- ✅ Repo injects liquidity; reverse repo and VRRR absorb liquidity.
- ✅ RBI uses multiple tools: repo, reverse repo, VRRR, OMOs, MSF, SDF, CRR, SLR, and FX operations.
- ✅ Liquidity management helps in monetary policy transmission, inflation control and financial stability.
- ✅ Recent move: ₹7 trillion, 30-day VRRR auction with early-redemption facility, against a ₹10.3 trillion banking-system liquidity surplus.

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

GS-III: Indian Economy

- Monetary policy and its tools
- Money and banking
- Financial markets
- Macroeconomic stability
- Inflation and growth

Also useful for:

- **Prelims:** Definitions, tools, current data
- **Mains:** Role of RBI in ensuring financial stability, transmission of monetary policy

SOUND LIQUIDITY MANAGEMENT FOR A STRONGER, STABLE AND INCLUSIVE INDIA

STABLE MARKETS STRONGER TOMORROW

INDIA'S FOREIGN EXCHANGE RESERVES HIT FRESH RECORD

RBI data show forex reserves at $740.8 billion

(for the week ended August 28, 2026)

Stronger dollar inflows, robust external sector and valuation gains have pushed India's reserves to a new high.

A STRONGER RUPEE A MORE RESILIENT INDIA

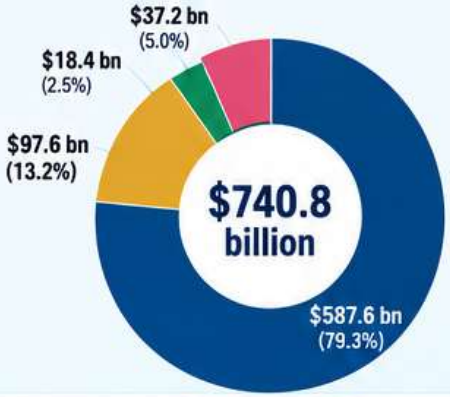
Forex Reserves
$740.8 billion
(as on August 28, 2026)
▲ New All-Time High

Increase
+$6.6 billion
(over previous week)

Previous Week
$734.2 billion
(as on August 21, 2026)

India's Forex Reserves among the LARGEST IN THE WORLD
(4th largest, after China, Japan, Switzerland)

COMPONENTS OF INDIA'S FOREX RESERVES (As on August 28, 2026)



- **Foreign Currency Assets (FCA)** — Assets in major foreign currencies (e.g., USD, EUR, GBP, JPY)
- **Gold Reserves** — Monetary gold held by RBI
- **Special Drawing Rights (SDRs)** — Reserve asset created by the IMF
- **IMF Reserve Position** — India's reserve position with the IMF

WHAT ARE FOREX RESERVES?

Foreign exchange reserves are external assets held by the RBI in foreign currencies, gold, SDRs and IMF reserve position. They act as a buffer against external shocks and help maintain stability in the exchange rate.

> "Adequate forex reserves strengthen macroeconomic stability, build investor confidence and help the economy withstand global uncertainties."
>
> – Reserve Bank of India

WHY DO FOREX RESERVES MATTER?

- **Stabilise the rupee** — Help RBI intervene in forex markets to prevent excessive volatility.
- **Meet external obligations** — Enable payment for imports, external debt, and other international commitments.
- **Build investor confidence** — A strong reserve position signals economic strength and creditworthiness.
- **Act as a buffer during crises** — Useful during global financial shocks, commodity price spikes or capital outflows.
- **Support macroeconomic stability** — Helps maintain low inflation and stable growth.

HOW ARE RESERVES BUILT?

- **Export earnings** — Receipts in foreign currency
- **Capital inflows** — FDI, FPI and external borrowings
- **RBI intervention** — Purchase of foreign currency in the market
- **Valuation gains** — Appreciation of non-USD assets (e.g., gold, euro, yen)

RBI AND EXCHANGE-RATE MANAGEMENT

- **Managed float** — RBI intervenes in the market to smoothen volatility, not to maintain a fixed rate.
- **Tools used**
  - Buying/selling dollars
  - Currency swaps
  - Forward contracts
  - Moral suasion and market communication
- **Objective** — Ensure orderly movement in the rupee and maintain overall macroeconomic and financial stability.

INDIA IN GLOBAL CONTEXT

Forex Reserves (US$ billion, latest available)

KEY FACTS FOR UPSC

- Foreign Currency Assets include government securities, treasury bills and other liquid assets.
- Gold reserves are valued at market prices.
- SDRs are international reserve assets created by the IMF in 1969.
- IMF reserve position reflects India's quota contribution and associated rights.
- RBI follows a managed floating exchange-rate regime.
- Adequate reserves are assessed using metrics like import cover, short-term external debt and composite adequacy frameworks (e.g., IMF ARA metric).

RELEVANCE FOR UPSC

- **GS-III: Indian Economy**
  - Balance of Payments
  - Exchange rate management
  - External sector and macroeconomic stability
- **Related topics:** IMF, SDRs, global financial architecture
- **Link with current affairs:** Global economic uncertainty, capital flows, dollar strength, commodity prices
- **Also relevant for:** Indian economic resilience and policy responses

2026-09-06
DAILY EDITION

READ
LEARN
STAY INFORMED
GROW

IMPORTANT DEVELOPMENTS. BROADER PERSPECTIVES.

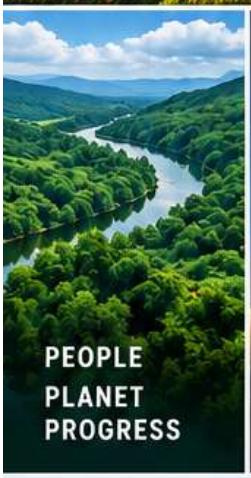
CURRENT AFFAIRS

DAILY DIGEST

NEWS THAT SHAPES A BETTER TOMORROW

POLITY & GOVERNANCE
ECONOMY
INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS
ENVIRONMENT
SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY
AGRICULTURE
GEOGRAPHY
POLICIES & SCHEMES

A MORE INFORMED INDIA FOR A BRIGHTER TOMORROW



SAME FACTS. A BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

INDIA'S VULTURE CONSERVATION
FROM CRISIS TO RECOVERY

Healthy Ecosystems | Safer Communities | A Vulture-friendly India

WHAT'S NEW?

6 September 2026

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- Workshop theme: **'From Crisis to Recovery – Conserving India's Vultures'.**
- Call for continued creation of **Vulture Safe Zones** and stronger technical capacity for species recovery in the wild.
- **Organised by:** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, Central Zoo Authority, Haryana Forest & Wildlife Department, Bombay Natural History Society, and Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre at Pinjore.

WHY VULTURES MATTER

- Scavengers rapidly dispose of carcasses.
- Reduce disease risk for humans and livestock.
- Help in nutrient cycling.
- Indicator of ecosystem health.

WHY POPULATIONS CRASHED

- Veterinary **diclofenac poisoning** through livestock carcasses was a major driver.
- Habitat and food-chain pressures.
- Unsafe carcass management and other threats.

VULTURE SAFE ZONE

- A landscape where threats are reduced, especially toxic veterinary drugs.
- Ensures safe food sources and proper carcass management.
- Involves monitoring, community participation and veterinary engagement.

INDIA FACTS

9 India has **nine vulture species.**

Examples:

- White-rumped Vulture
- Indian (Long-billed) Vulture
- Slender-billed Vulture
- Red-headed Vulture
- Egyptian Vulture
- Himalayan Griffon

CONSERVATION TOOLKIT

- Captive breeding and reintroduction.
- Drug safety and veterinary awareness (e.g. ban on diclofenac).
- Habitat protection and safe carcass management.
- Population monitoring and research.
- Community participation and multi-stakeholder action.

PINJORE CENTRE

Jatayu Conservation Breeding Centre (JCBC) at Pinjore, Haryana

- A major conservation-breeding facility for vultures.
- In 2025–26, it housed **356 vultures** and bred **35 chicks.**

PRELIMS BOX

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In-situ: Vulture Safe Zones (in the wild).
Ex-situ: Conservation breeding in facilities like JCBC, Pinjore.

Vultures Today
Healthier Tomorrows

SAVE VULTURES
SAVE ECOSYSTEMS
SAVE LIVES

INDIA – SRI LANKA
DEFENCE & MARITIME PARTNERSHIP
Stronger Neighbours, A Safer Indian Ocean

PEACE
STABILITY
PROSPERITY
IN THE INDIAN OCEAN

WHAT'S NEW?

Rajnath Singh visit: 8 – 10 Sept 2026

High-level India delegation
Including officials from Defence and External Affairs

Focus: defence + maritime cooperation
Will hold consultations with Sri Lankan leadership and interact with the Indian diaspora in Colombo.

INDIA AND SRI LANKA: KEY MARITIME GEOGRAPHY

WHY SRI LANKA MATTERS

- **India's closest southern maritime neighbour**
- **Located beside key Indian Ocean sea lanes**
- **Palk Strait & Gulf of Mannar link the two countries**
- **Important for regional security and Indian Ocean stability**

DEFENCE COOPERATION

- **SLINEX:** India–Sri Lanka bilateral naval exercise
- **MITRA SHAKTI:** bilateral army exercise
- **IN – SLN DIVEX:** diving & submarine-rescue cooperation
- **HADR** and maritime interoperability

STRATEGIC CONTEXT

- **Neighbourhood First**
- **Security and Growth for All in the Region (SAGAR)**
- **Maritime domain awareness**
- **Countering non-traditional security threats**

PRELIMS FACTS

- **Sri Lanka** lies south of India
- **Palk Strait** separates Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka
- **Gulf of Mannar** is between southeast India and western Sri Lanka
- **Colombo** is a major Indian Ocean port

A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP
FOR A STABLE AND PROSPEROUS INDIAN OCEAN

BIG DEVELOPMENT

6 SEPTEMBER 2026

INDIA–JAPAN

ELEVATE TIES TO A NEW STRATEGIC PHASE

STRONGER
PEOPLE • PROSPERITY
• A STABLE INDO-PACIFIC

During the recent visit of Japan's Prime Minister **Shigeru Ishiba** to India (5–6 Sept 2026), the two countries launched a **new 10-year roadmap** to deepen the **India–Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.**

'VISION FOR THE NEXT DECADE'

A forward-looking plan to make India–Japan cooperation more ambitious, people-centric and impactful, anchored in shared democratic values.

PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE & HUMAN RESOURCE MOBILITY

- Target to facilitate **500,000 people-to-people exchanges** in the next decade.
- Greater opportunities for students, skilled professionals and cultural exchanges.

ECONOMIC & INVESTMENT TIES

- Aim to invest **₹10 lakh crore** in India over the next 10 years.
- Focus on infrastructure, manufacturing, clean energy, semiconductors and startups.
- Stronger collaboration for resilient and diversified supply chains.

GREEN GROWTH & SUSTAINABILITY

- Enhanced cooperation in clean energy, energy transition and climate action.
- Collaboration on green hydrogen, battery technologies and sustainable infrastructure.
- Support for a low-carbon, climate-resilient and inclusive growth model.

DEFENCE & SECURITY COOPERATION

- Further strengthen defence and strategic ties.
- Greater collaboration in maritime security, a free, open and rules-based **Indo-Pacific.**
- Enhanced defence industrial cooperation and technology exchange.

TECHNOLOGY & INNOVATION

- Deeper cooperation in AI, semiconductors, quantum technologies, space and next-generation technologies.
- Joint research, innovation ecosystems and startup **linkages.**

REGIONAL & GLOBAL COOPERATION

- Reaffirm committment to a free, open, inclusive and prosperous **Indo-Pacific.**
- Closer coordination in multilateral forums (**Quad, G20**, UN, etc.).
- Shared efforts for peace, stability and a rules-based international order.

TWO DEMOCRACIES. A STRONGER TOMORROW.

INDIA – JAPAN

GLOBAL BIOFUELS ALLIANCE

CLEAN ENERGY. STRONGER TOMORROW.

A global partnership led by India to accelerate the adoption of sustainable biofuels.

WHAT IS IT?

An international initiative launched by **India** in 2023 during the G20 presidency.

Aims to create a global ecosystem for production, use and trade of sustainable biofuels (bioethanol, biodiesel, SAF, biogas, etc.).

Brings together governments, international organisations, industry and research institutions.

MEMBERS

12 MEMBER COUNTRIES

India, USA, Brazil, Argentina, Canada, Italy, Mauritius, South Africa, UAE, Singapore, Bangladesh, and 1 more

INTERNATIONAL ORGANISATIONS

- **IEA** – International Energy Agency
- **IRENA** – International Renewable Energy Agency
- **FAO** – Food and Agriculture Organization

KEY FOCUS AREAS

- Scale up production and use of biofuels (ethanol, biodiesel, SAF, biogas)
- Facilitate technology development and knowledge sharing
- Promote sustainable and resilient supply chains
- Mobilise finance and investment
- Develop common standards and certification
- Support policy cooperation and capacity building

WHY BIOFUELS?

- Lower greenhouse gas emissions
- Cleaner air and better public health
- Reduces dependence on imported fossil fuels
- Helps rural economy and farmers (use of agri-residues like sugarcane, rice straw, etc.)

INDIA'S RELATED INITIATIVES

- Ethanol Blending Programme (20% by 2025–26)
- Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) roadmap
- Waste to Wealth Mission
- National Bioenergy Programme
- 2G ethanol and advanced biofuel research

CHALLENGES

- Sustainable and consistent feedstock supply
- Higher production costs compared to fossil fuels
- Need for advanced technology and infrastructure
- Harmonising global standards
- Balancing food security with biofuel expansion

FROM FIELDS TO A GREENER FUTURE

BIOFUELS **DRIVE ENERGY SECURITY, RURAL PROSPERITY AND A CLEANER PLANET.**

SUSTAINABLE ENERGY | STRONGER FARMERS | CLEANER ENVIRONMENT | A HEALTHIER PLANET

INDIA LAUNCHES MAITRI-II

A NEW ERA FOR INDIA'S POLAR RESEARCH

India's second indigenously built polar research vessel, MAITRI-II, has been launched, marking a major step in strengthening India's presence in the Antarctic and the Southern Ocean.

STRONGER SCIENCE
SAFER PLANET
A GREATER INDIA

EXPLORATION
RESEARCH
CLIMATE ACTION

ABOUT MAITRI-II

- **Type:** Polar Research Vessel (ice-class)
- **Built by:** Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), Kolkata
- **Indigenously designed and built**
- **Launched:** September 2026
- **Purpose:** Support India's Antarctic missions, scientific research and logistics supply

KEY FEATURES

- **Ice-breaking capability** — Can navigate through sea ice in polar regions
- **Accommodation** — For ~100 scientists, crew and support staff
- **Advanced laboratories** — For oceanography, climate, marine biology and earth sciences
- **Helideck** — Supports helicopter operations for logistics and research
- **Cargo capacity** — Carries fuel, food and equipment for long-duration missions
- **Environment-friendly** — Designed with low emissions and complies with modern environmental standards

INDIA'S ANTARCTIC PROGRAMME

- **Began in 1981** with the first Indian Antarctic Expedition
- **Research stations:** Maitri (1989) and Bharati (2012)
- **Focus areas:** climate change, glaciology, oceanography, atmospheric sciences, biology and geology
- **Operated by:** National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), Ministry of Earth Sciences

WHY IT MATTERS

- Strengthens India's scientific research in the Antarctic and Southern Ocean
- Helps in better understanding climate change and its impact on India's monsoon and coastal regions
- Supports strategic presence in a resource-rich and geopolitically important region
- Enhances India's role in global polar governance and scientific collaboration
- Facilitates study of oceans, biodiversity and extreme environments

THE ANTARCTIC TREATY

- Signed in 1959, in force since 1961
- Designates Antarctica for peaceful purposes and scientific research
- Prohibits military activity, nuclear explosions and disposal of nuclear waste
- India is a Consultative Party (since 1983) with voting rights

A CLEANER, SAFER PLANET

- Polar research helps monitor global climate change
- Provides early warning for sea-level rise and extreme weather
- Contributes to a sustainable and resilient future

FROM THE POLAR OCEAN TO A SAFER TOMORROW

SCIENCE | SUSTAINABILITY | A STRONGER INDIA

INDIA'S NATIONAL CRITICAL MINERAL MISSION (NCCM)

SECURING RESOURCES FOR A SELF-RELIANT AND CLEAN ENERGY FUTURE

CRITICAL MINERALS STRONGER INDIA

WHAT IS NCCM?

A flagship mission by the Government of India to ensure long-term and sustainable availability of **critical minerals** for India's **economic growth, clean energy transition and strategic autonomy.**

LAUNCHED

JANUARY 2025

Total outlay:
₹34,300 CRORE
(2025–2031)

WHY IT MATTERS?

- Supports **clean energy** (renewable energy, EVs, energy storage)
- Reduces **import dependence**
- Enhances **strategic** and **economic security**
- Enables **high-technology** manufacturing
- Essential for India's **net-zero** climate goal

KEY OBJECTIVES

- Increase **domestic exploration** and mining of critical minerals
- Secure overseas mineral assets
- Develop processing and recycling capabilities in India
- Build a skilled workforce and strong R&D ecosystem

CRITICAL MINERALS INCLUDE

Lithium (EV batteries)	**Cobalt** (Batteries, superalloys)	**Nickel** (Batteries, stainless steel)
Rare Earth Elements (Magnets, electronics)	**Copper** (Clean energy, electricals)	**Graphite** (Batteries, nuclear)

MAJOR COMPONENTS

- **Geological mapping** and mineral exploration
- Acquisition of overseas mines and strategic partnerships
- Setting up processing, refining and value addition facilities
- Promoting recycling and urban mining
- Research, innovation and skilling initiatives

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS

- First set of critical mineral blocks identified for auction in India
- Discussions underway for overseas assets in resource-rich countries (Australia, Africa, Latin America)
- Focus on building domestic processing and refining capacity
- Industry and global partners showing strong interest

THE BIGGER PICTURE

CRITICAL MINERALS POWER THE TECHNOLOGIES OF TOMORROW –
CLEANER PLANET, STRONGER ECONOMY, SECURE INDIA.

- RENEWABLE ENERGY
- ELECTRIC VEHICLES
- ELECTRONICS
- DEFENCE
- GREEN HYDROGEN

MINERALS FOR A SUSTAINABLE TOMORROW

INDIA - EU
FREE TRADE AGREEMENT

A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP FOR A MORE PROSPEROUS FUTURE

TRADE
PEOPLE
PLANET
PROSPERITY

STRONGER INDIA
STRONGER EUROPE
A MORE STABLE WORLD

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

Negotiations for the **India–EU Free Trade Agreement** (FTA) concluded in **September 2026.**

The agreement is now moving towards **legal review, translation and formal approval.**

KEY FEATURES (REPORTED)

- Reduction or elimination of tariffs on majority of traded goods
- Better market access for services (IT, finance, professional services, etc.)
- Facilitation of investments and easier regulatory processes
- Cooperation in technology, innovation and digital trade
- Focus on sustainable trade, clean energy and critical raw materials
- Provisions for labour rights, environmental standards and inclusive growth

INDIA–EU TRADE: AT A GLANCE

EU is India's largest trading partner.

Total trade (2024–25):
~€137 billion
(≈ ₹12.5 lakh crore)

India's exports to EU: **~€75 billion**

India's imports from EU: **~€62 billion**

EU accounts for **~17%** of India's total trade.

WHAT IS IT?

A comprehensive trade agreement to reduce tariffs, remove trade barriers and deepen economic cooperation between India and the European Union.

WHY IT MATTERS?

- Creates new opportunities for Indian goods, services and investments in the EU market.
- Strengthens strategic partnership democracies.
- Supports resilient and diversified global supply chains.
- Helps in green transition, clean energy and sustainable development.

KEY SECTORS THAT MAY BENEFIT

- Textiles, leather, marine products
- Automobiles and auto components
- Pharmaceuticals and chemicals
- Electronics and electrical goods
- Agriculture and processed food
- IT and business services
- Gems and jewellery
- Renewable energy and green technologies

THE ROAD AHEAD

- Legal scrubbing and translation (othe agreement text)
- Approval by the European Council, European Parliament and India's cabinet
- Final signing and ratification
- Implementation and monitoring mechanisms

DEEPER TIES
BRIGHTER OPPORTUNITIES

INDIA & EU
PARTNERS
IN PROGRESS

PEOPLE
INFORMED
SOCIETIES
STRONGER

IDEAS
PEOPLE
PROGRESS
A STRONGER INDIA

KNOW
TODAY
BUILD
TOMORROW

CURRENT AFFAIRS

DAILY DIGEST

07 SEPTEMBER 2026 | DAILY EDITION

IMPORTANT DEVELOPMENTS.
BROADER PERSPECTIVES.

NEWS THAT SHAPES A BETTER TOMORROW.

- POLITY & GOVERNANCE
- ECONOMY
- INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS
- ENVIRONMENT
- SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY
- AGRICULTURE
- GEOGRAPHY
- PUBLIC POLICY

A MORE INFORMED INDIA FOR A BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

FACTS TODAY. A STRONGER TOMORROW.

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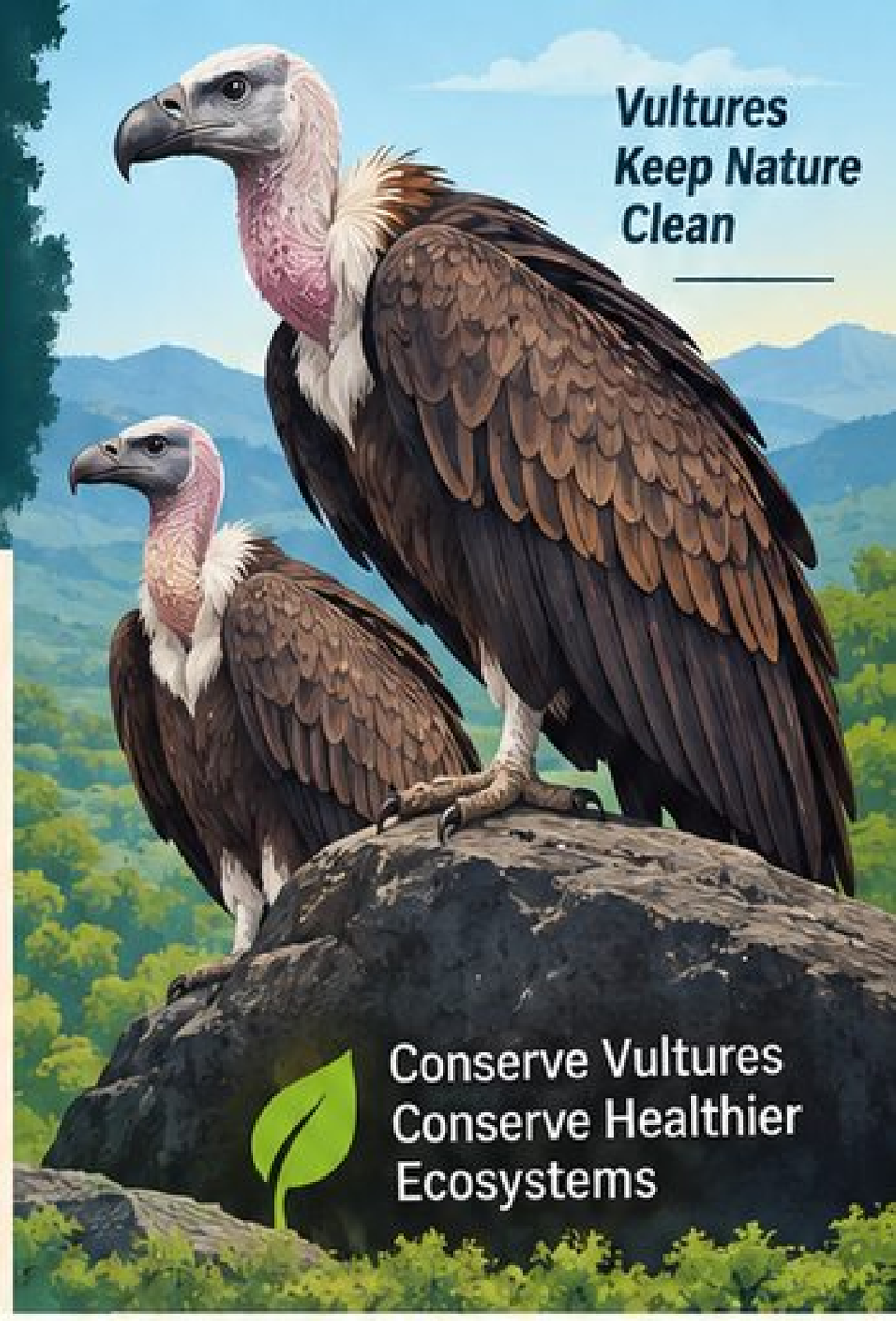
FROM CRISIS TO RECOVERY

Healthy Ecosystems | Safer Communities | A Vulture-friendly India



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Vultures Today
Healthier Tomorrows

SAVE VULTURES
SAVE ECOSYSTEMS
SAVE LIVES

2026-09-06
CURRENT AFFAIRS

INDIA'S BIODIVERSITY GOVERNANCE FRAMEWORK

RICH BIODIVERSITY
STRONGER COMMUNITIES
A SUSTAINABLE TOMORROW

PEOPLE
NATURE
SUSTAINABLE
INDIA

BIODIVERSITY
SECURES
OUR FUTURE

CONSERVE TODAY. THRIVING TOMORROW.

WHAT'S NEW?

- 16th National Meet held at **Chandigarh**
- **Focus:** implementation of biodiversity governance at State & local levels
- Brings together State Biodiversity Boards and UT Biodiversity Councils

LEGAL BACKBONE

- Biological Diversity Act, 2002
- Biological Diversity Rules
- Access & Benefit Sharing (ABS)
- Conservation + sustainable use + fair benefit sharing

THREE-TIER INSTITUTIONAL STRUCTURE

National Biodiversity Authority (NBA)
NATIONAL LEVEL

→

State Biodiversity Boards (SBBs)
STATE LEVEL

→

Biodiversity Management Committees (BMCs)
LOCAL BODIES

PEOPLE'S BIODIVERSITY REGISTERS

- Prepared locally by BMCs
- Document local biological resources
- Record traditional knowledge associated with biodiversity

ACCESS & BENEFIT SHARING

- Ensures benefits from use of biological resources are shared fairly
- May include monetary and non-monetary benefits
- Links conservation with community incentives

PRELIMS FACTS

- NBA headquarters: **Chennai**
- BMCs are constituted by local bodies
- Biological diversity governance links Centre, States and local institutions
- India is a party to the Convention on Biological Diversity (CBD)

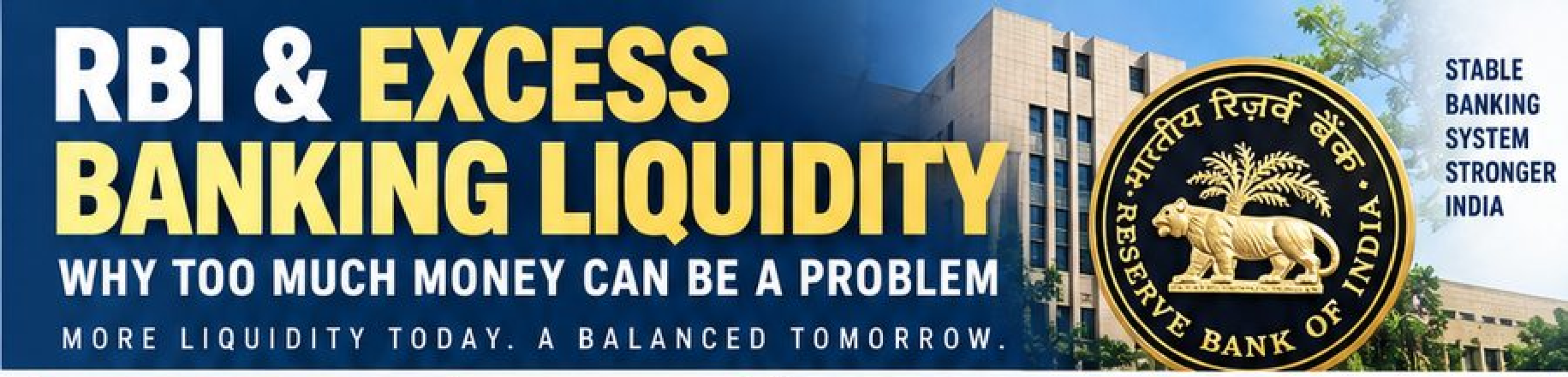
WHY LOCAL GOVERNANCE MATTERS

- Conservation is site-specific
- Communities hold ecological and traditional knowledge
- Local monitoring improves implementation

RBI & EXCESS BANKING LIQUIDITY

WHY TOO MUCH MONEY CAN BE A PROBLEM

MORE LIQUIDITY TODAY. A BALANCED TOMORROW.



STABLE BANKING SYSTEM STRONGER INDIA

WHAT'S NEW?

₹10.3 lakh crore

Banking system liquidity surplus (as on 3 Sept 2026)

Highest in about **four years**

RBI using **VRRR** to absorb excess funds

₹6.02 lakh crore

absorbed on 4 Sept 2026 through **VRRR** auctions

WHAT IS LIQUIDITY?

- **Funds readily available** with banks.
- **Surplus liquidity** = banks have more funds than immediate system demand.
- **Deficit liquidity** = banks need RBI funding.

WHY EXCESS LIQUIDITY MATTERS

- Can push **overnight money-market** rates below policy repo rate.
- **Weakens monetary-policy transmission.**
- **May add inflationary pressure** if prolonged.
- **Requires liquidity sterilisation / absorption.**

RBI TOOLKIT TO MANAGE LIQUIDITY

Variable Rate Reverse Repo (VRRR)
Banks park funds with RBI at a variable auction-determined rate.

Standing Deposit Facility (SDF)
Absorbs liquidity without collateral.

Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)
Portion of deposits kept with RBI (earns no interest).

Open Market Operations (OMO) and forex operations can alter rupee liquidity.

MONETARY POLICY CORRIDOR

Higher rate

MSF (Marginal Standing Facility) — Upper bound of the corridor

Repo Rate — Policy signal (mid-point)

SDF (Standing Deposit Facility) — Lower bound of the corridor

Lower rate

WACR (Weighted Average Call Rate) is RBI's operating target.

PRELIMS FACTS

- **Repo** injects liquidity against collateral (to banks).
- **Reverse repo / VRRR-type** operations absorb liquidity.
- **CRR** balances earn no interest.
- **Sterilisation** offsets the liquidity impact of forex intervention.

HOW FOREX INFLOWS LEAD TO EXCESS LIQUIDITY

Foreign currency inflows → **RBI buys dollars** (in forex market) → **Rupees enter the banking system** → **Banking liquidity rises**

Absorption tools (VRRR, SDF, CRR, OMO) pull surplus rupees back from the system.

SOUND MONEY. A STRONGER TOMORROW.

INDIA'S 3-YEAR ROADMAP FOR A DRUG-FREE INDIA

SAFER PEOPLE | STRONGER COMMUNITIES | A HEALTHIER NATION

SAY NO TO DRUGS
BUILD A BRIGHTER INDIA

1 WHAT'S NEW?

3-year roadmap:

July 2026 → July 2029

Goal: stronger national action against drug trafficking and substance abuse

Enforcement + coordination + prevention + rehabilitation

2 INDIA'S ANTI-DRUG ARCHITECTURE

Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB)
- Central coordinating and enforcement agency

Ministry of Home Affairs
- Key nodal ministry for narcotics control

State police and anti-narcotics units
- Ground enforcement

Multi-agency coordination is essential
- Trafficking crosses borders and jurisdictions

3 LEGAL BACKBONE

NDPS Act, 1985

- Controls and regulates narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances
- Provides stringent penalties for illicit trafficking
- Also permits regulated medical/scientific use under law

4 FOUR-PILLAR RESPONSE

Supply reduction
Disrupt trafficking networks

Demand reduction
Prevention and awareness

Treatment & rehabilitation
Support people with substance-use disorders

International cooperation
Intelligence and border coordination

5 WHY DRUG TRAFFICKING IS A SECURITY ISSUE

- Organised crime networks
- Cross-border trafficking
- Money laundering and illicit finance
- Potential links with other transnational crimes

6 PRELIMS FACTS

- NCB established in **1986**
- **NDPS** = Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances
- India is located between the **Golden Crescent** and Golden Triangle trafficking regions
- **Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan** focuses on demand reduction and awareness

7 TRAFFICKING GEOGRAPHY

India's location makes it vulnerable due to proximity to two major illicit drug production regions.

Golden Crescent and **Golden Triangle** are major global centres of illicit **drug production** and trafficking.

DRUG-FREE INDIA | HEALTHY YOUTH | PROSPEROUS NATION

WESTERN ZONAL COUNCIL

CENTRE – STATE COORDINATION & COOPERATIVE FEDERALISM

DIALOGUE | COOPERATION | STRONGER STATES | A STRONGER INDIA

PANAJI
GOA

7 SEPT 2026

Stronger Together for a Developed India

WHAT'S NEW?

- **28th Western Zonal Council meeting**
- **Panaji, Goa — 7 Sept 2026**
- **Platform for Centre–State and inter-State coordination**

ZONAL COUNCILS

- Created under the **States Reorganisation Act, 1956**
- Statutory bodies — **NOT constitutional bodies**
- Five zonal councils: **Northern, Central, Eastern, Western, Southern**
- North Eastern Council is separate and governed by the NEC Act, 1971

WESTERN ZONAL COUNCIL MEMBERS

- **Goa**
- **Gujarat**
- **Maharashtra**
- **Union Territory of Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu**

WHO CHAIRS?

- **Union Home Minister:** common Chairman of the five Zonal Councils
- **Chief Ministers** of member States: Vice-Chairman by annual rotation
- **Administrators/LG** of member UTs participate

WHAT DO THEY DISCUSS?

- Inter-State issues
- Border, transport and infrastructure coordination
- Internal security
- Social and economic planning
- Implementation of national programmes

WHY THEY MATTER

- **Cooperative federalism**
- **Consultation before conflict**
- **Regional coordination**
- **Faster resolution of shared administrative problems**

PRELIMS TRAPS

- Zonal Councils ≠ Inter-State Council
- Inter-State Council: **Article 263** of Constitution
- Zonal Councils: **States Reorganisation Act, 1956**
- NEC is not one of the five Zonal Councils

COOPERATIVE STATES | PROSPEROUS REGIONS | VIKSIT BHARAT

7 SEPT 2026
NEW DELHI

A STRONGER PARTNERSHIP
FOR A STABLE AND PROSPEROUS
INDO-PACIFIC

PEACE
PROSPERITY
PEOPLE
PLANET

15th INDIA–JAPAN ANNUAL SUMMIT

STRONGER TIES FOR A SHARED FUTURE

WHEN & WHERE

7 September 2026
New Delhi, India

LEADERS

Prime Minister **Narendra Modi** & Prime Minister **Shigeru Ishiba**

SIGNIFICANCE

Reviewed progress, set new goals and reaffirmed commitment to a free, open, inclusive and rules-based Indo-Pacific

KEY OUTCOMES

ENHANCED STRATEGIC COOPERATION

Reaffirmed Special Strategic and Global Partnership

ECONOMIC & INVESTMENT TIES

Focus on resilient supply chains, clean energy, infrastructure and emerging technologies

DEFENCE & SECURITY

Greater collaboration in maritime security, cyber, space and defence industry

GREEN & CLEAN ENERGY

Cooperation on renewable energy, hydrogen, energy efficiency and climate action

PEOPLE-TO-PEOPLE EXCHANGES

Boost in education, skill development, tourism and cultural ties

INDIA–JAPAN RELATIONS

- **1952** Establishment of diplomatic relations
- **2000** 'Global Partnership'
- **2006** 'Strategic and Global Partnership'
- **2014** Special Strategic and Global Partnership
- **2016** India–Japan Civil Nuclear Agreement
- **2017** Annual Summit mechanism
- **2022** 70 years of diplomatic relations
- **2026** 15th Annual Summit

MAJOR AREAS OF COOPERATION

Trade & Investment
Japan is a major source of FDI in India

Infrastructure
Flagship project: Mumbai–Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail (Bullet Train)

Technology & Innovation
Semiconductors, AI, digital, start-ups

Maritime Cooperation
Peace, security and stability in the Indo-Pacific

Sustainable Development
Clean energy, green hydrogen, resilient supply chains

INDO-PACIFIC VISION

Both nations reiterated their commitment to a free, open, inclusive and rules-based Indo-Pacific, with respect for international law and freedom of navigation.

TWO DEMOCRACIES.
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW.

SMALL MODULAR REACTORS FOR ANDAMAN & NICOBAR ?

CLEAN ENERGY | STRONGER ISLANDS | A SECURE INDO-PACIFIC

SITE ASSESSMENT / PROPOSAL

NOT YET AN OPERATING REACTOR

WHAT'S NEW?

4–8 SEPT 2026

- **DAE/BARC** team assessing sites across Andaman & Nicobar Islands
- Site assessments: **4–8 Sept 2026**
- **Purpose:** examine nuclear options for future island power demand

WHAT IS AN SMR ?

- **Small Modular Reactor**
- Typically up to **~300 MW(e)** per module
- Factory-fabricated modules can reduce on-site construction time
- Designed for scalable deployment

WHY ISLANDS ?

- Isolated grids
- High dependence on transported fuels
- Growing infrastructure and strategic power needs
- Need reliable low-carbon baseload alongside renewables/storage

INDIA'S NUCLEAR GOVERNANCE

DAE	Department of Atomic Energy (Union government)
BARC	Nuclear R&D
NPCIL	Major nuclear power plant operator
AERB	Nuclear and radiation safety regulator

STRATEGIC GEOGRAPHY

SMR: PROMISE vs CHALLENGES

PROMISE

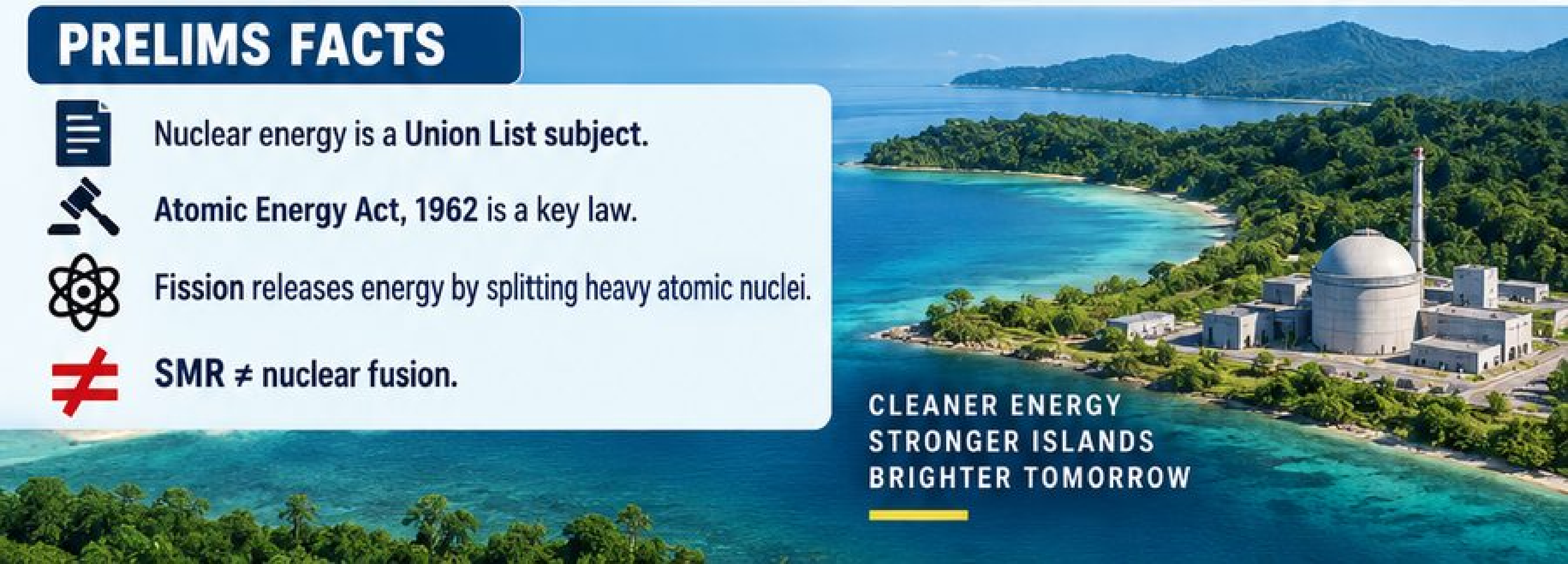
- Lower-carbon firm power
- Modular scaling
- Potential fit for smaller grids

CHALLENGES

- Safety & regulation
- Radioactive waste management
- High upfront economics
- Island ecology & disaster resilience

PRELIMS FACTS

- Nuclear energy is a **Union List subject.**
- **Atomic Energy Act, 1962** is a key law.
- **Fission** releases energy by splitting heavy atomic nuclei.
- **SMR ≠ nuclear fusion.**



CLEANER ENERGY
STRONGER ISLANDS
BRIGHTER TOMORROW

7 SEPT 2026
LATEST UPDATE

SIMPLER TAX. STRONGER INDIA.

GST 2.0

NEXT-GENERATION REFORM FOR A SIMPLER, FAIRER AND STRONGER ECONOMY

The GST Council has approved a simplified two-rate structure, sweeping rate rationalisation and key changes effective from **22 September 2026.**

FROM FOUR RATES TO TWO
A SIMPLER GST STRUCTURE

EARLIER

5% 12% 18% 28%

NOW

5% 18%

Higher 40% rate only for sin goods (e.g. tobacco, pan masala, luxury items)

WHAT GETS CHEAPER?
LOWER TAX ON EVERYDAY ESSENTIALS

- **Food items** — Many daily use items moved to 5%
- **Healthcare** — Greater relief on medicines and medical devices
- **Education** — Select items and services at 5%
- **Agriculture** — Inputs and equipment cheaper
- **Automobiles** — Small cars and two-wheelers attract lower tax

WHAT CHANGES?

- Rate rationalisation across a large number of items
- Several goods and services shifted from 12% and 28% to 5% or 18%
- Aim to reduce classification disputes and compliance burden
- Expected to boost consumption, manufacturing and formalisation

EXPECTED IMPACT

- Lower prices for households
- Higher demand and economic growth
- Support to MSMEs and job creation
- More competitive and self-reliant India

GOODS AND SERVICES NOW AT 0%

- Specified lifesaving drugs and rare disease medicines
- Specified defence items
- Select educational materials

A separate list of 0% items has been notified.

IMPLEMENTATION

- New rates effective from **22 September 2026**
- Detailed notifications and item-wise lists to be issued by the Government

SIMPLER COMPLIANCE • STRONGER BUSINESSES • BRIGHTER TOMORROW

INDIA–ASEAN SUMMIT 2026

STRONGER PARTNERSHIP FOR A STABLE, PROSPEROUS INDO-PACIFIC

India and ASEAN leaders held the 22nd India–ASEAN Summit, reaffirming their commitment to a peaceful, secure and rules-based Indo-Pacific.

22nd INDIA–ASEAN SUMMIT

- 7 September 2026
- New Delhi, India
- Leaders of all 10 ASEAN countries and the Prime Minister of India

THEME

"ASEAN–India: A Partnership for Peace, Progress and People"

PARTICIPATION

10 ASEAN member countries + Prime Minister of India

KEY OUTCOMES

- Adopted a Joint Statement to further deepen the **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership**
- Reaffirmed commitment to a free, open, inclusive and rules-based Indo-Pacific
- Agreed to enhance cooperation in trade, connectivity, maritime security, digital transformation, clean energy, health and people-to-people ties
- Discussed regional and global issues of mutual interest

FOCUS AREAS

- Trade & Investment
- Maritime Security & Blue Economy
- Digital Transformation & Emerging Technologies
- Green Transition & Clean Energy
- People-to-People and Cultural Exchanges
- Counter-Terrorism, Cybersecurity and Transnational Crime

WHAT IS ASEAN?

Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN) is a regional organisation of 10 Southeast Asian countries, established in 1967 to promote peace, **stability** and economic cooperation in the region.

Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Vietnam

A stronger India–ASEAN partnership contributes to a more peaceful, prosperous and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

LATEST DEVELOPMENT

7 September 2026
New Delhi

INDIA–MAURITIUS ELEVATE TIES TO ENHANCED STRATEGIC PARTNERSHIP

During the Mauritius Prime Minister's visit to India (4–9 September 2026), the two countries announced the elevation of bilateral ties to an **"Enhanced Strategic Partnership".**

WHAT HAPPENED?

- India and Mauritius decided to upgrade their relationship to an **Enhanced Strategic Partnership.**
- Several agreements and MoUs signed across key areas of cooperation.
- Reaffirmed commitment to a free, open, inclusive and secure **Indian Ocean Region.**

KEY AREAS OF COOPERATION

- Maritime Security & Coastal Surveillance
- Trade, Investment & Blue Economy
- Digital Public Infrastructure & Innovation
- Climate Change, Disaster Resilience & Renewable Energy
- People-to-People Ties, Education & Capacity Building

SIGNIFICANCE

- Builds on a long-standing and close friendship.
- Strengthens cooperation in the Indian Ocean, a key region for India's security and economic interests.
- Supports Mauritius' development priorities and India's **MAHASAGAR vision** (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Security and Growth Across Regions).

ABOUT MAURITIUS

- Island nation in the Indian Ocean, east of Madagascar.
- Strategic location along key maritime sea lanes.
- A close and trusted partner of India with strong people-to-people links (large Indian-origin population).
- Important for India's vision of a stable, secure and prosperous Indian Ocean Region.

STRONGER INDIA–MAURITIUS TIES
FOR A PEACEFUL, INCLUSIVE AND PROSPEROUS INDIAN OCEAN

FRONT-OF-PACK FOOD WARNING LABELS

INDIA'S POLICY DEBATE

HEALTHIER PEOPLE STRONGER INDIA

WHAT'S NEW?

- **Supreme Court challenge** to proposed food-warning framework filed by a public-health group (7 September 2026).
- **Issue: threshold design** for front-of-pack warnings.
- **Hearing reported for 10 September 2026.**

HOW THE PROPOSAL WORKS

Red warning proposed when at least 2 of 3 exceed limits:

- **Added sugar**
- **Salt / Sodium**
- **Saturated fat**

Debate: should one excessive nutrient alone trigger a warning?

WHY FRONT-OF-PACK LABELLING?

- **Quick consumer information.**
- **Supports healthier choices.**
- **Targets diet-related non-communicable diseases (NCDs).**
- **Complements detailed nutrition panels.**

GOVERNANCE

- **FSSAI regulates food safety and standards.**
- **Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.**
- **Ministry of Health & Family Welfare.**
- **Supreme Court reviewing the challenge.**

PUBLIC POLICY BALANCE

- **Consumer right to information.**
- **Public health.**
- **Scientific threshold-setting.**
- **Compliance burden and food-industry impact.**

PRELIMS FACTS

- **FSSAI** = Food Safety and Standards Authority of India.
- **FSSAI** is a statutory body.
- Food safety is governed principally by the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.
- NCDs include cardiovascular disease, diabetes and some cancers.

GLOBAL CONCEPT

- **Front-of-pack labels may use warnings, symbols or nutrient scores.**
- **Goal: make nutrition risk easier to understand at purchase.**

Examples globally: warning labels (e.g., high in sugar), traffic light systems, or nutrient scores (e.g., Nutri-Score).

PROPOSAL UNDER COURT REVIEW

NOT A FINAL SUPREME COURT RULING

A HEALTHIER FOOD ENVIRONMENT BUILDS A HEALTHIER TOMORROW

CURRENT AFFAIRS DAILY DIGEST

WEDNESDAY
09
SEPTEMBER 2026

Facts Today for a Brighter Tomorrow

KEY DEVELOPMENTS | BIGGER PICTURE | A MORE INFORMED YOU

POLITY & GOVERNANCE

Governance Reforms, Policies and Institutions

ECONOMY

Markets, Industry, Trade and Growth Trends

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

Global Developments, Strategic Partnerships and Geopolitics

ENVIRONMENT

Climate Action, Biodiversity and Sustainable Development

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Innovation, Research and a Brighter Future

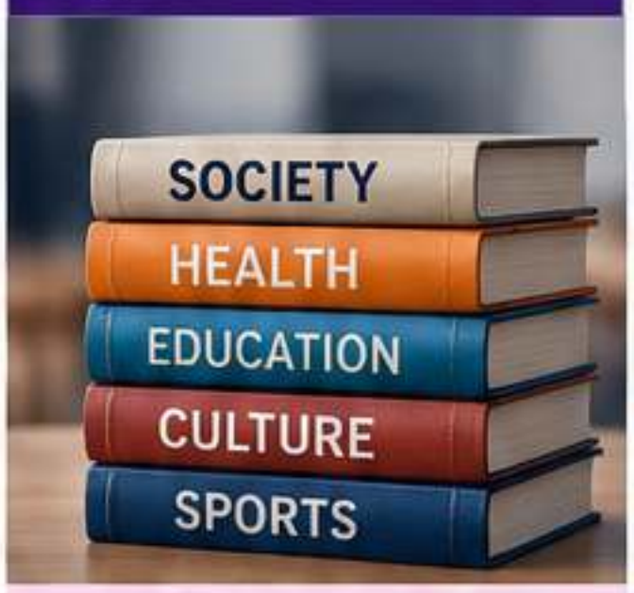
AGRICULTURE

Farming, Food Security and Rural Development

GEOGRAPHY

Places, People and the Changing World

MISCELLANEOUS



People, Society, Health, Education, Culture and More

CURRENT AFFAIRS 9 SEPT 2026

KHARIF SOWING 2026
PADDY AREA DOWN 4% AS MONSOON DEFICIT BITES

Uneven rainfall leads to lower paddy area, raises yield risks for pulses and oilseeds, but large rice stocks provide a buffer.

WHAT HAPPENED?

PADDY AREA (2026)
42.18 million hectares
↓ 4% (year-on-year)

TOTAL KHARIF AREA
108.63 million hectares
↓ 1.6% (year-on-year)

Deficient and uneven monsoon rainfall is a key factor behind the lower paddy area and overall kharif sowing.

CROP PICTURE (AREA UNDER SOWING)

PULSES
11.71 million hectares
↑ Increased (year-on-year)

OILSEEDS
19.19 million hectares
↓ Slightly lower (year-on-year)

Area coverage does not equal final production. Yields depend on rainfall distribution, irrigation, pests and weather during crop development.

MONSOON → AGRICULTURE LINK

Rainfall affects sowing timing, soil moisture, reservoir recharge and crop yields.

Uneven spatial and temporal distribution can be as important as the all-India seasonal total.

A ~14.4% monsoon rainfall deficit has been reported, with uneven spread across regions.

FOOD SECURITY BUFFER

70.86 million tonnes
Government's kharif paddy procurement target (2026).

Large public rice stocks can cushion near-term supply risk. Procurement and buffer stocks support the food-security system.

PRELIMS FACTS

- Kharif crops are generally sown with the southwest monsoon and harvested in autumn.
- Major kharif crops: rice, maize, cotton, soybean, groundnut and several pulses.
- MSP is announced before sowing seasons for notified crops.
- FCI maintains central pool foodgrain stocks.

MAINS ANGLE

Climate-resilient agriculture requires:

- Irrigation efficiency
- Drought-tolerant varieties
- Crop diversification
- Better weather advisories
- Water budgeting
- Region-specific cropping choices

WATCH NEXT

- Monsoon distribution
- Reservoir levels
- Crop yields
- Food inflation
- Procurement arrivals

RAINFALL DISTRIBUTION → YIELDS → FOOD PRICES → RURAL INCOME

STRONGER FARMS STRONGER INDIA

9 SEPT 2026

HEALTHY CHILDREN
HEALTHY FAMILIES
A BRIGHTER INDIA

NOURISHED
COMMUNITIES
STRONGER
TOMORROWS

9th RASHTRIYA POSHAN MAAH 2026

NUTRITION THROUGH COMMUNITY ACTION

Sahi Poshan Saksham Bharat

India launches the ninth Rashtriya Poshan Maah on 9 September 2026 in Varanasi.

Observed every September since 2018, this month-long campaign mobilises communities around nutrition, health and caregiving behaviours.

WHAT IS POSHAN MAAH?

- Annual September campaign for nutrition awareness and behaviour change
- Mobilises communities at the grassroots
- 9th edition in 2026

WHO IS AT THE CENTRE?

- Pregnant women
- Lactating mothers
- Children (0–6 years)
- Adolescents
- Families
- Anganwadi Centres as frontline community institutions

CORE THEMES

- Balanced and protein-rich diets
- Maternal nutrition
- Infant and young child feeding
- Growth monitoring
- Hygiene and healthy practices

POLICY ECOSYSTEM

- POSHAN Abhiyaan launched in 2018
- Mission Saksham Anganwadi & Poshan 2.0 integrates nutrition support, early childhood care and Anganwadi strengthening
- Ministry of Women and Child Development is the nodal Union ministry

PRELIMS FACTS

- Anganwadi Services originated under ICDS
- Frontline workers include Anganwadi Workers and Helpers
- Nutrition outcomes require convergence across health, sanitation, drinking water and food systems

MEASURE PROGRESS

- Stunting (low height for age)
- Wasting (low weight for height)
- Underweight (low weight for age)
- Anaemia (across age groups)

MAINS ANGLE

Malnutrition is multidimensional: food quality and diversity, maternal health, sanitation, disease burden, women's agency, household income and effective last-mile delivery all matter.

BETTER NUTRITION → BETTER LEARNING → STRONGER HUMAN CAPITAL

India's Semiconductor Mission

6 New Projects Approved on 9 September 2026

A major boost to India's chip manufacturing ecosystem, adding ~₹1.6 lakh crore in investment and strengthening the goal of a self-reliant electronics supply chain.

CHIPS FOR A VIKSIT BHARAT

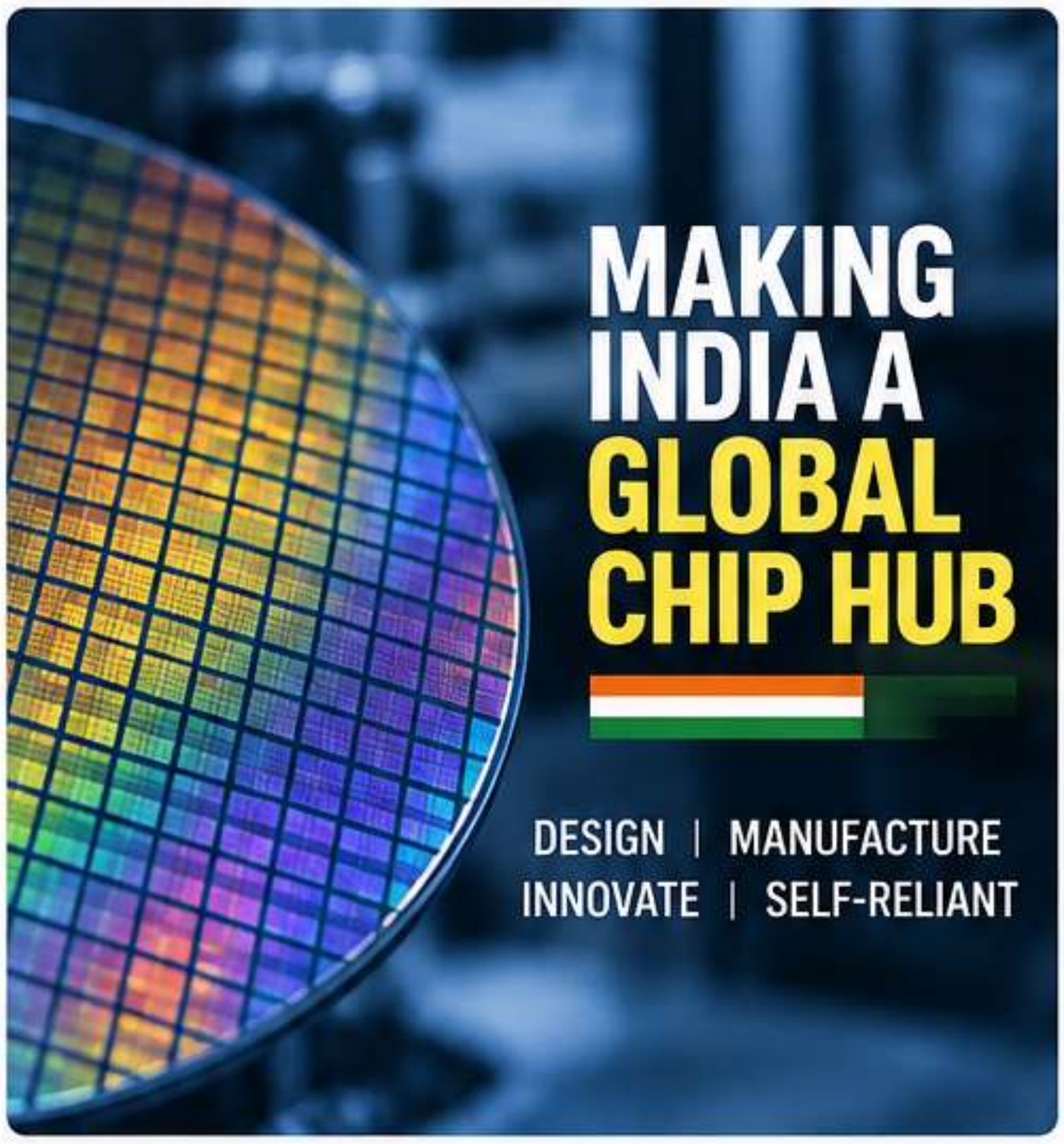
6 PROJECTS AT A GLANCE

Total investment
~₹1.6 lakh crore

Expected direct jobs
~7,000

Indirect jobs
~34,000

Spread across
5 states
(Andhra Pradesh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Punjab and Uttar Pradesh)



WHAT WILL BE SET UP?

Semiconductor fabs (2 projects)
Manufacturing of chips for a wide range of applications

ATMP units (3 projects)
Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging

Compound semiconductor unit (1 project)
For next-generation electronics, high-power and high-frequency devices

Focus areas
- Consumer electronics
- Automotive
- Industrial electronics
- Telecom and 5G/6G
- AI and high-performance computing

PART OF A LARGER VISION

- Under the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM)
- Aims to build a resilient and self-reliant semiconductor ecosystem
- Attracts global and domestic investment
- Supports India's growing electronics manufacturing and digital economy

RECENT MILESTONES

- With these 6 projects, total approved projects under ISM now **10**
- Cumulative investment: **~₹1.76 lakh crore**
- Positions India as a key player in the global semiconductor value chain

SEMICONDUCTORS
POWER A SMARTER,
STRONGER, SELF-RELIANT INDIA

PEOPLE | PARTNERSHIPS | INNOVATION | PROSPERITY

FCI MODERNISATION 2026–27

OUTCOME-BASED FOODGRAIN MANAGEMENT

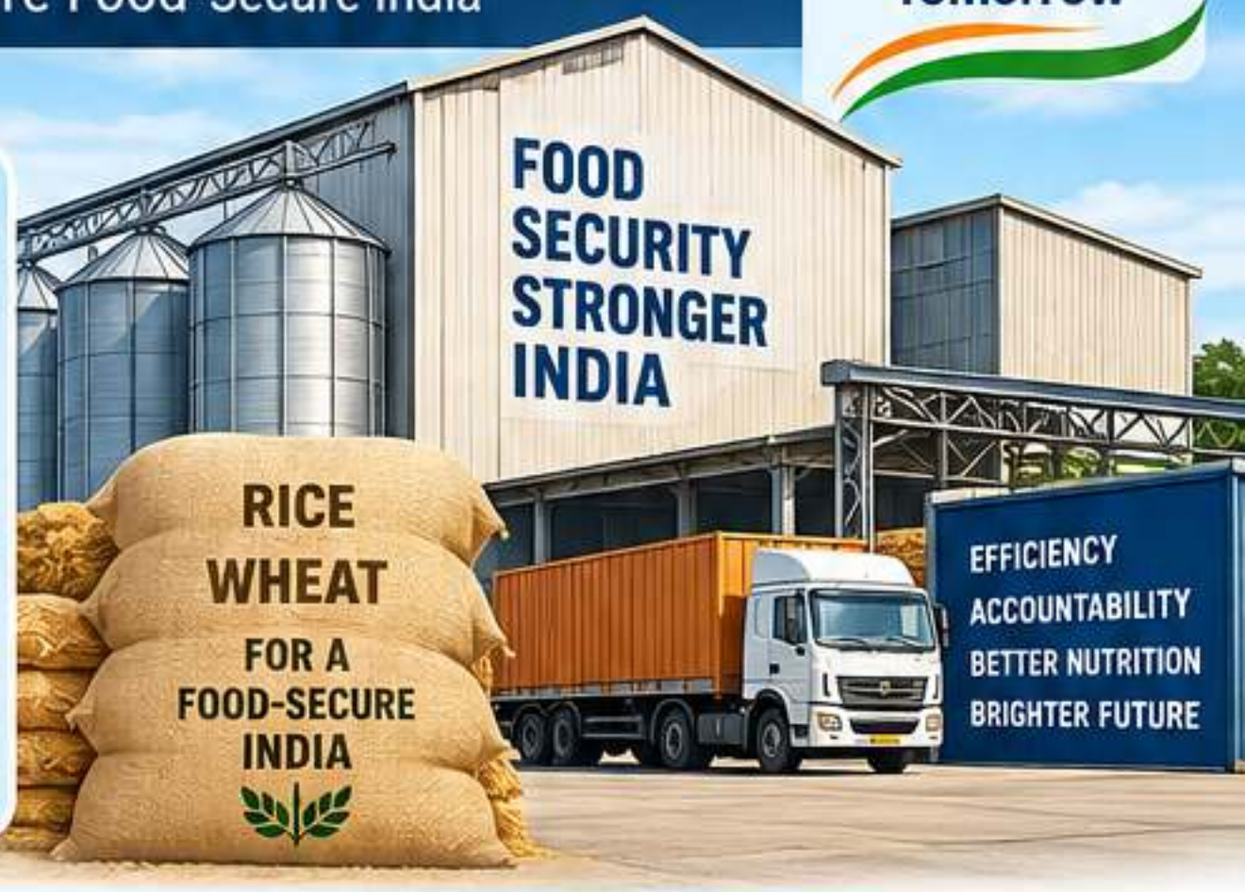
Stronger Systems | Safer Food | A More Food-Secure India

9 SEPT 2026

From Grain Security to a Stronger Tomorrow

WHAT CHANGED?

Department of Food and Public Distribution (DFPD) and Food Corporation of India (FCI) signed an MoU for **FY 2026–27**, creating an **outcome-oriented performance framework** with defined annual targets for FCI to improve operational efficiency, accountability and modernisation in foodgrain management.



SIX PRIORITY AREAS

1. Reduce storage losses
2. Optimise warehouse capacity
3. Improve logistics and supply chains
4. Strengthen quality control
5. Digitise business processes and monitoring
6. Train personnel for modern systems

FCI IN INDIA'S FOOD SECURITY SYSTEM

- Procures foodgrains at **MSP** operations as assigned by government
- Maintains **Central Pool stocks**
- **Stores and moves** foodgrains across India
- **Supplies** grain for the **Public Distribution System** and other welfare schemes

POLICY LINKAGES

- **National Food Security Act, 2013** provides legal entitlements to subsidised foodgrains for eligible beneficiaries
- **Central Pool stocks** support distribution and food-security management
- **Buffer norms** help ensure operational and strategic availability

WHY MODERNISATION MATTERS

- Lower wastage and better grain preservation
- Better inventory visibility
- Faster movement from surplus to deficit regions
- Improved grain quality and food safety
- Lower carrying and logistics costs
- Greater transparency and accountability

PRELIMS FACTS

- FCI was established in **1965** under the **Food Corporations Act, 1964**.
- Administrative ministry: **Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution.**
- **DFPD** is a department under that ministry.

MANS ANGLE

Food security depends not only on production and procurement but also efficient storage, scientific handling, logistics, digital traceability, fiscal sustainability and timely last-mile delivery.

PROCURE → STORE → MOVE → DISTRIBUTE – EFFICIENTLY

9 SEPT 2026

GLOBAL TENSIONS. HIGHER OIL. A WEAKER RUPEE.

RUPEE BREACHES ₹95/$

OIL SHOCK TESTS INDIA'S EXTERNAL STABILITY

Rupee weakens past 95 per dollar as crude prices surge and global uncertainty deepens.

WHAT HAPPENED?

- Indian rupee breached ₹95 per US dollar, touching about 95.2250 on 9 Sept 2026.
- Brent crude moved towards $100 per barrel amid escalating Middle East tensions and supply-disruption fears.
- Rupee was the worst-performing Asian currency during the session.
- RBI is understood to have intervened in the forex market, but external dollar demand and oil pressures overwhelmed support.

WHY OIL HITS THE RUPEE?

- India imports around 85% of its crude oil needs.
- Higher oil prices increase the import bill and demand for dollars.
- This can widen the current-account deficit (CAD) and put pressure on the rupee.
- Rupee depreciation can make imports costlier and feed into domestic inflation.

RBI'S TOOLKIT

- Forex-market intervention using reserves to manage volatility.
- Liquidity management and monetary-policy signalling.
- RBI generally manages excessive volatility rather than defending a permanently fixed exchange rate.

EXTERNAL-SECTOR CHAIN

Crude oil prices ↑ → Import bill ↑ → Dollar demand ↑ → Rupee pressure → Imported inflation risk ↑

PRELIMS FACTS

- India follows a market-determined exchange-rate system with RBI intervention (to manage excessive volatility).
- Forex reserves include foreign currency assets, gold, SDRs and India's reserve position with the IMF.
- The current account (CAD) is a component of the Balance of Payments (BoP).

MAINS ANGLE

- Greater resilience requires diversified energy sources and higher domestic renewable capacity.
- Prudent external borrowing and adequate forex buffers.
- Competitive exports to strengthen the current account.
- A credible and consistent macroeconomic policy framework is essential.

WATCH NEXT

- Brent crude price trend
- RBI intervention
- Forex reserves level
- Current-account deficit (CAD)
- Imported inflation data

ENERGY SECURITY IS ALSO MACROECONOMIC SECURITY

INDIA'S SPONGE IRON PRICES HIT 2-YEAR HIGH

COAL SUPPLY SHOCK HITS STEEL CHAIN

WHAT HAPPENED?

India's benchmark sponge iron price reached about

₹29,700 per tonne

in August 2026, its **highest in two years**, as imported coal became more expensive and domestic coal availability tightened.

WHAT IS SPONGE IRON?

Sponge iron, or Direct **Reduced Iron (DRI)**, is made by reducing iron ore below its melting point.

It is an important feedstock for **secondary steelmaking**, especially in electric and induction furnaces.

Solid-state reduction (rather than melting) makes it different from pig iron produced in a blast furnace.

WHY COAL MATTERS

- Many Indian DRI plants **use non-coking coal** as a reducing agent and fuel.
- **Imported coal costs have risen** due to higher **freight** and insurance costs amid Middle East tensions.
- **Domestic coal supply tightened** as coal was prioritised for power generation during high summer demand.
- **Monsoon rains** also **disrupted mining** operations and rail logistics.

INDIA'S POSITION

India is the world's largest sponge iron producer, with about **336 plants** producing around **50 million tonnes** annually.

ECONOMIC TRANSMISSION

ENERGY-INDUSTRY TRADE-OFF

Prioritising coal for electricity security can tighten industrial supply, highlighting the challenge of balancing power demand with the needs of steel and other industries. It also underscores the need for better logistics and fuel diversification.

PRELIMS FACTS

- Coking coal is mainly used in blast-furnace steelmaking.
- Non-coking coal can be used in coal-based DRI.
- DRI uses solid-state reduction, unlike pig iron produced through melting in a blast furnace.

MAINS ANGLE

Resilient steel supply chains need better domestic coal logistics, energy efficiency, gas and green-hydrogen DRI pathways, recycling and lower-carbon production while maintaining affordable industrial inputs.

WATCH NEXT

Coal imports | Rail availability | Steel prices | Power demand | Green-hydrogen DRI

SECURE RESOURCES. STRONGER INDUSTRIES. BRIGHTER INDIA.

9 SEPT 2026

MORE SUPPLY. LOWER PRICES. STABLE MARKETS.

SUGAR SUPPLY POLICY

DUTY-FREE RAW SUGAR IMPORTS & EARLY CRUSHING

Government allows duty-free imports of 1 million tonnes of raw sugar and asks mills to start crushing on 15 October to cool record-high domestic prices.

WHAT CHANGED?

- Duty-free raw sugar import quota: **1 million tonnes**
- Port refineries can seek quota to sell refined sugar domestically
- Around **250,000 tonnes** of quota applications expected from refineries
- Sugar mills asked to start crushing on **15 October**, nearly a month earlier than usual

WHY GOVERNMENT INTERVENED

- Record-high domestic sugar prices
- Rising demand during festival season
- Need to augment near-term supply
- Moderate food inflation

HOW THE SUPPLY CHAIN WORKS

Imports can supplement domestic output when supplies are tight.

SUGAR POLICY TOOLKIT

- Import duties / quotas
- Export controls
- Monthly release mechanisms
- Crushing-season timing
- Ethanol diversion policy (from sugarcane/ molasses)
- Stock monitoring and buffer management

ECONOMY LINK

- Sugar prices affect food inflation (CPI).
- Sugarcane supports farm incomes and rural employment.
- Diversion to ethanol creates a food-versus-fuel allocation trade-off.

PRELIMS FACTS

- Sugarcane is a long-duration tropical/subtropical crop.
- Major producing states: Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka.
- India is among the world's largest sugar producers and consumers.
- Ethanol can be produced from sugarcane juice, B-heavy molasses and other feedstocks (subject to policy).

MAINS ANGLE

A stable sugar policy requires balancing consumer prices, farmer cane dues, mill viability, ethanol blending, water use and predictable trade policy.

WATCH NEXT

- Retail sugar prices
- Import arrivals and domestic offtake
- Progress of October crushing
- Cane output estimates
- Ethanol allocation decisions

FARM INCOME ⟷ FOOD PRICES ⟷ ETHANOL ⟷ TRADE POLICY

9 SEPT 2026

SAFER FOOD | HEALTHIER PEOPLE | STRONGER INDIA

FRONT-OF-PACK FOOD WARNING LABELS

INDUSTRY CHALLENGES FSSAI PLAN IN SUPREME COURT

Health warnings on packaged foods are now at the centre of a major legal and policy debate in India.

WHAT HAPPENED?

- India's packaged-food industry has filed its **first major** legal objection to the government's proposed front-of-pack warning-label system.
- The **Supreme Court** will review the matter.

PROPOSED LABEL SYSTEM

- **Red hexagon** warning on the front of pack.
- Triggered when a product exceeds limits in at least **two of three** categories:

GOVERNANCE FRAMEWORK

- **FSSAI** sets food-safety and labelling standards under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.
- Ministry of Health & Family Welfare is the administrative ministry.
- Courts can review whether regulations comply with constitutional and statutory requirements.

PUBLIC HEALTH LOGIC

- Clearer front-of-pack warnings can help consumers identify products high in salt, sugar and saturated fat.
- Linked to obesity, diabetes, hypertension and other non-communicable disease risks.

HEALTHIER FOOD ENVIRONMENTS CAN REDUCE NCD BURDEN

INDUSTRY'S ARGUMENT

- Proposed thresholds may be overly stringent.
- Seeks a per-serving approach rather than per-100-gram thresholds.
- Concern that broad warning coverage could affect many products.

PRELIMS FACTS

- FSSAI is a statutory body under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006.
- Food labelling is a regulatory tool for consumer information.
- NCD prevention involves diet, physical activity and public-health regulation.

MAINS ANGLE

Effective food regulation must balance consumer right to information, public-health goals, scientific evidence, regulatory certainty and proportional compliance costs.

WATCH NEXT

- Supreme Court observations
- Final FSSAI thresholds
- Implementation timeline
- Industry compliance rules

INFORMED CHOICES → BETTER DIETS → LOWER NCD BURDEN

CURRENT AFFAIRS
DAILY DIGEST
10 SEPTEMBER 2026

POLITY & GOVERNANCE

Institutions • Rights • Reforms

ECONOMY

Growth • Markets • Financial Stability

INTERNATIONAL RELATION

India’s partnerships • Global developments

ENVIRONMENT

Climate resilience • Sustainability

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

Innovation • Research • Emerging technology

AGRICULTURE

Food security • Farmers • Rural development

ClearExams

Concise • Relevant • Exam-ready

10 SEPT 2026

SAFE SEEDS | STRONGER FARMERS | A FOOD SECURE INDIA

NEW SEED LAW

INDIA MOVES TO CRACK DOWN ON FAKE & SUBSTANDARD SEEDS

Stronger laws for quality seeds, farmer protection and a more resilient agriculture sector.

WHAT IS HAPPENING?

- Government is preparing a new **Seed Act.**
- Union Agriculture Minister is holding a nationwide consultation with major farmer organisations on **10 September 2026** at Krishi Bhawan before the legislation is finalised.
- Farmer experiences and suggestions will inform the draft.

WHY A NEW FRAMEWORK?

- Fake or poor-quality seed can cause **crop failure** and heavy income loss for farmers.
- Traceability and enforcement gaps weaken farmer protection.
- Reliable seed quality supports higher productivity and food security.

CORE IDEAS

- **Stringent action against fake, adulterated and substandard seeds.**
- **Stronger seed-quality standards.**
- **End-to-end traceability from production to sale.**
- **Accountability of companies and traders.**
- **Protection of farmers' traditional-seed rights.**

SEED GOVERNANCE BASICS

- Regulation covers quality standards, labelling, sale and enforcement.
- Central and state institutions share implementation responsibilities.
- Plant-variety protection and farmers' rights are related but distinct from seed-quality regulation.

PRELIMS FACTS

- **Seeds Act, 1966** is a key existing seed-quality law.
- **Seeds (Control) Order, 1983** regulates seed dealers under the Essential Commodities framework.
- **Protection of Plant Varieties and Farmers' Rights Act, 2001** covers breeders' and farmers' rights.

AGRICULTURE LINK

- Quality seed is a foundational farm input.
- Genetic purity, germination, physical purity and seed health influence crop performance.
- Traceability can help quickly identify defective seed lots and prevent wider losses.

MAINS ANGLE

Reform must balance farmer protection, **innovation** and investment, affordable access, biodiversity, traditional seed systems, testing capacity and enforceable accountability.

WATCH NEXT

- Draft bill text.
- Treatment of farmer-saved / traditional seed.
- Certification and registration rules.
- Penalties for violations.
- Traceability requirements.
- Parliamentary process.

QUALITY SEED → PRODUCTIVITY → FARM INCOME → FOOD SECURITY

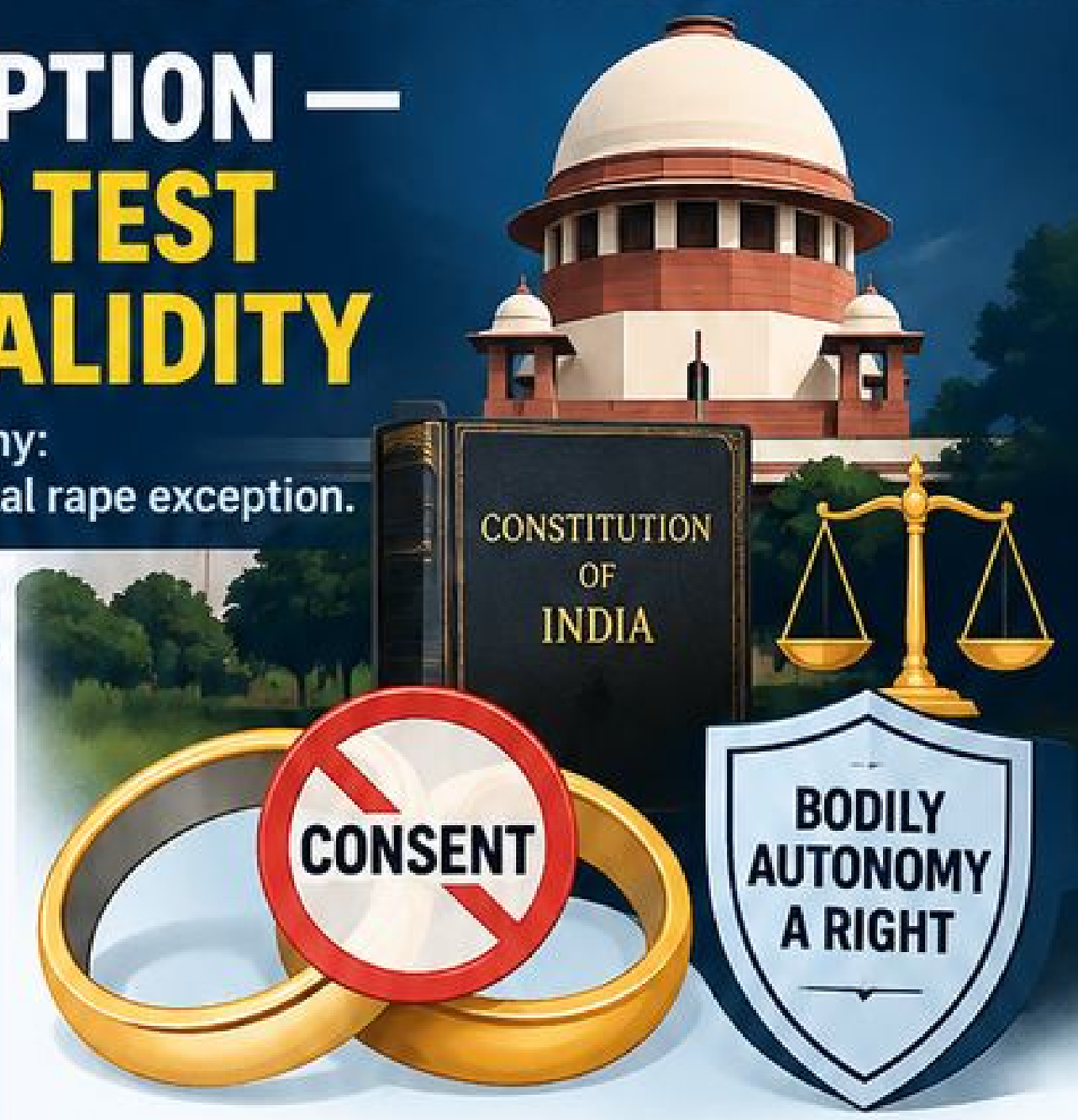
GOOD SEEDS TODAY A STRONGER TOMORROW

10 SEPT 2026

RIGHTS. JUSTICE. A STRONGER INDIA.

MARITAL RAPE EXCEPTION — SUPREME COURT TO TEST CONSTITUTIONAL VALIDITY

Marriage does not extinguish individual autonomy: Supreme Court to examine challenges to the marital rape exception.



WHAT HAPPENED?

- Supreme Court will **begin final hearing after about three weeks** on petitions challenging the marital rape exception.
- Challenges concern the exception under IPC and now under the BNS.
- Court will test whether the exception survives constitutional scrutiny.

WHAT DOES CURRENT LAW SAY?

- **Exception 2 to Section 63** of the **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS)** excludes sexual acts by a man with his own wife from the offence of rape.
- The wife must **not be under 18 years** of age for the exception to apply.
- BNS replaced the IPC from **1 July 2024.**

CORE CONSTITUTIONAL QUESTIONS

Article 14	Equality before law and protection against arbitrariness.
Article 21	Right to life, dignity, privacy and bodily autonomy.
Article 20(1)	No conviction for an act that was not an offence under the law in force when committed.
Separation of powers	Limits of judicial interpretation versus Parliament's law-making role.

COURT'S DILEMMA

- Court observed that individual **autonomy** continues within marriage.
- But can courts permit rape prosecution while Parliament has expressly retained an exception?
- The Court says the constitutionality of the exception must be examined.

"Marriage does not extinguish individual autonomy."

SUPREME COURT

IMPORTANT BACKGROUND

- **Delhi High Court** delivered a **split verdict** in 2022 on the marital rape exception.
- **Karnataka High Court** allowed prosecution of a husband in a case that is now before the Supreme Court.
- Supreme Court's **2017 Independent Thought** judgment protected minor wives by reading the age threshold consistently with 18 years.

PRELIMS FACTS

- **Section 63 BNS** defines rape and contains the marital exception.
- **Article 14** guarantees equality before law and equal protection.
- **Article 20(1)** protects against ex-post-facto criminal liability.
- **Article 21** protects life and personal liberty.

MAINS ANGLE

- Consent and bodily autonomy within marriage.
- Equality and protection from sexual violence.
- Misuse concerns and due-process safeguards.
- Institutional competence: judicial adjudication or legislative reform.

WATCH NEXT

- Final hearing before the Supreme Court.
- How the Court treats Section 63 exception.
- Outcome in the Karnataka appeal.
- Centre's arguments that criminalisation is for Parliament.
- Whether the Court strikes down, reads down or upholds the provision.

MARRIAGE • CONSENT • AUTONOMY • EQUALITY • RULE OF LAW

BRICS SUMMIT 2026

INDIA'S MULTILATERALISM & GLOBAL SOUTH AGENDA

12 – 13 SEPTEMBER 2026 | NEW DELHI, INDIA

10 SEPT 2026
LATEST DEVELOPMENT

WHAT IS HAPPENING?

- India hosts the **18th BRICS Summit** in New Delhi on **12–13 September 2026.**
- Leaders will focus on **"Inclusive Global Governance and Strengthening Multilateralism"** in the opening closed session.

INDIA'S PRIORITIES

- Resilient supply chains
- Startups and innovation
- Green energy and sustainable development
- Practical cooperation for the Global South
- Reform of international institutions

WHAT IS BRICS?

- An intergovernmental/plurilateral grouping of major emerging economies.
- Decisions are **consensus-based.**
- Chairship rotates among members.
- Cooperation spans political-security, economic-financial and people-to-people areas.

WHY MULTILATERAL REFORM?

- Emerging economies seek a greater voice in institutions created under older global power structures.
- **Key issues:** fairer representation, development finance and stronger responses to cross-border challenges like climate change, pandemics and food-energy security.

FINANCIAL COOPERATION

- Discussions include cross-border **payments** and greater use of **national currencies** in trade and settlements.
- **Not the same as an imminent single BRICS currency.**
- Aim is to reduce transaction costs and enhance financial resilience.

NEW DEVELOPMENT BANK (NDB)

NDB

- Created by BRICS members in 2014 through the Fortaleza process.
- Headquartered in Shanghai, China.
- Finances infrastructure and sustainable-development projects in member and other developing countries.

INDIA'S BALANCING ROLE

- India supports a multipolar, reformed international order.
- Emphasis on strategic autonomy, consensus and practical development cooperation rather than bloc confrontation.

PRELIMS FACTS

- BRICS began with Brazil, Russia, India and China; South Africa joined later.
- NDB was established through the Fortaleza process in 2014.
- BRICS has no permanent secretariat like the UN.

MAINS ANGLE

BRICS gives India a platform to advance Global South priorities, institutional reform and development cooperation, but internal geopolitical differences and differing economic interests can limit collective action.

WATCH NEXT

- **New Delhi summit declaration**
- Language on UN/IMF reform
- Progress on payment systems and national currencies
- Supply-chain initiatives
- Green-energy cooperation
- Possibility of future expansion

STRATEGIC AUTONOMY • MULTIPOLARITY • GLOBAL SOUTH • REFORMED MULTILATERALISM

10 SEPT 2026

AI TODAY • STRONGER ECONOMIES TOMORROW

AI BOOM & FINANCIAL STABILITY BIS FLAGS NEW RISKS

HUGE OPPORTUNITIES. REAL RISKS. A MORE COMPLEX GLOBAL ECONOMY.

WHAT HAPPENED?

- **BIS head Pablo Hernández de Cos** warns that the **AI investment boom creates new financial-stability risks.**
- Remarks made at an **RBI-hosted conference in India.**
- AI can boost productivity but may also amplify financial vulnerabilities.

SCALE OF THE BOOM

Top five global tech firms:

> $1 trillion

AI infrastructure investment estimated for **2025–26.**

Broader globa. AI investment could approach

$4 trillion by 2030.

WHY CENTRAL BANKS CARE

- AI simultaneously changes aggregate demand, productive capacity, labour markets, asset valuations and financing conditions.
- This makes inflation, growth and financial-risk assessment harder.

A MORE INTERCONNECTED AND COMPLEX ECONOMY

FINANCIAL-STABILITY CHANNEL

- **Large capital expenditure** on AI infrastructure.
- Greater **debt** and **private-credit** financing.
- **Opaque exposures** can make leverage and risk concentration harder to monitor.
- **Rapid asset-price expectations** can **reverse** if returns disappoint.

PRODUCTIVITY UPSIDE

- Generative AI can improve productivity in specific tasks such as coding and professional writing.
- Economy-wide gains depend on diffusion, complementary infrastructure, skills, competition and movement of workers/ capital to productive uses.

HUMAN SKILLS + AI HIGHER PRODUCTIVITY

INDIA ANGLE

- India's digital public infrastructure and technology workforce create opportunities.
- Priorities include AI skills, compute and energy infrastructure, responsible finance, competition and worker transition.

SKILLS
INFRASTRUCTURE
INCLUSIVE GROWTH

PRELIMS FACTS

- **BIS** is an international organisation serving central banks and is headquartered in Basel, Switzerland.
- **Financial stability** means the financial system can perform core functions and absorb shocks.
- **Private credit** refers broadly to lending outside traditional public bond markets and often outside conventional bank lending channels.

MAINS ANGLE

- Policymakers must capture AI-driven productivity while guarding against leverage, concentration, labour displacement and unequal access. Innovation policy and macro-financial regulation need to evolve together.

WATCH NEXT

- AI investment financing
- Private-credit exposure
- Productivity data
- Labour-market effects
- Semiconductor supply chains
- Central-bank financial-stability assessments

AI PRODUCTIVITY + SOUND FINANCE + SKILLS = RESILIENT GROWTH

TECHNOLOGY FOR PEOPLE • STABILITY FOR PROGRESS • A STRONGER TOMORROW

10 SEPT 2026

ASEAN–INDIA AGRICULTURE PLAN 2026–2030

FOOD SECURITY, CLIMATE RESILIENCE & DIGITAL FARMING

Deepening cooperation for sustainable, resilient and inclusive agriculture across South and Southeast Asia

STRONGER FARMS
STRONGER REGION
BRIGHTER TOMORROW

PEOPLE
CROPS
PLANET
PROSPERITY
TOGETHER

SHARED SOLUTIONS
FOR A FOOD-SECURE AND RESILIENT TOMORROW

WHAT HAPPENED?

9th **ASEAN–India Ministerial Meeting on Agriculture and Forestry** held in **New Delhi.**

India and ASEAN backed stronger farmer-centred cooperation for **2026–2030.**

CORE PRIORITIES (2026–2030)

- **Climate-resilient farming**
- **Sustainable and low-emission agriculture** (including rice systems)
- **Digital and AI-enabled agriculture**
- **Joint research and innovation**
- **Capacity building and farmer exchanges**
- **Resilient food and agricultural supply chains**

WHY IT MATTERS

- South and Southeast Asia face climate shocks, food-price volatility, pests, water stress and supply-chain disruption.
- Regional cooperation can share technology, germplasm, research and good practices.

RESILIENT
FARMS
STRONGER
PEOPLE

INDIA–ASEAN FRAMEWORK

- Agriculture and forestry cooperation sits within the **ASEAN–India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership.**
- Ministers welcomed **ASEAN 2045: Our Shared Future** and the **ASEAN Food, Agriculture and Forestry Sectoral Plan 2026–2030.**

A STRONGER
AND MORE PROSPEROUS
INDO-PACIFIC

GENE RESOURCES

- NBPGR is India's nodal institution for management of plant genetic resources.
- Germplasm conservation supports crop breeding, biodiversity and climate resilience.

CONSERVING
DIVERSITY
FOR A RESILIENT FUTURE

LOW-EMISSION RICE

- Rice cultivation can emit methane under flooded conditions.
- Improved water and crop-management practices can reduce emissions while maintaining productivity.

CLIMATE-SMART RICE
FOR A GREENER TOMORROW

PRELIMS FACTS

- ASEAN was established in 1967.
- Its Secretariat is in Jakarta.
- India is a dialogue partner, not an ASEAN member.
- ICAR is India's apex agricultural research body.
- NBPGR works on plant genetic resources.

MAINS ANGLE

Agricultural diplomacy can connect food security, climate adaptation, biodiversity, technology sharing and Global South cooperation, but implementation requires financing, farmer access and locally suitable technologies.

WATCH NEXT

- Projects under the 2026–2030 plan
- AI/digital agriculture cooperation
- Low-emission rice initiatives
- Germplasm and research exchanges
- Resilient regional food supply chains

FOOD SECURITY · CLIMATE RESILIENCE · INNOVATION · REGIONAL COOPERATION

THRIVING
FARMERS
STRONGER
TOMORROWS

FACTS
IDEAS
INSIGHTS
FOR A
BRIGHTER
TOMORROW

ClearExams

LEARN TODAY LEAD TOMORROW

Small Updates Big Picture

CURRENT AFFAIRS

DAILY DIGEST

15 SEPTEMBER 2026

POLITY & GOVERNANCE | ECONOMY | INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS | ENVIRONMENT | SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY | AGRICULTURE

STAY INFORMED
STAY AHEAD

A MORE INFORMED A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

KNOW TODAY. BUILD TOMORROW.

WORLD CIRCULAR ECONOMY FORUM 2026 OPENS IN GANDHINAGAR

PEOPLE | RESOURCES | A MORE RESILIENT TOMORROW

TOWARDS A RESOURCE-EFFICIENT AND SUSTAINABLE WORLD

15 – 18 September 2026 | **Gandhinagar, Gujarat, India**

Global ideas.
Circular solutions.
A cleaner, greener tomorrow.

WHAT IS A CIRCULAR ECONOMY?

An economic model that reduces waste and resource extraction by designing products and systems around reuse, repair, refurbishment, remanufacturing and recycling.

IN CONTRAST, THE LINEAR MODEL FOLLOWS:

"Take – Make – Dispose"

KEY CONCEPTS

Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR)
Makes producers responsible for specified post consumer waste management.

Resource Efficiency
Creating greater economic value with fewer material and energy inputs.

SDG 12
Responsible Consumption and Production.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR INDIA

- Resource security
- Lower waste generation
- Reduced material import dependence
- Industrial competitiveness
- Green jobs
- Climate mitigation
- Sustainable consumption and production

A SHARED GLOBAL PLATFORM

- Brings together governments, industry, innovators and civil society
- Showcases circular-economy approaches and India's initiatives on resource circularity
- Encourages knowledge exchange and collaboration for a sustainable future

RESOURCES CIRCULATE. OPPORTUNITIES GROW.

A CLEANER, GREENER, MORE RESILIENT TOMORROW

GREAT INDIAN BUSTARD

NEW SOFT-RELEASE CENTRE OPENS AT NALIYA, KACHCHH

GRASSLANDS TODAY BRIGHTER TOMORROW

A major step to strengthen conservation efforts for one of India's most threatened birds.

Conserving Tomorrow's Skies

WHAT'S NEW?

A dedicated Great Indian Bustard soft-release centre has been inaugurated at Naliya in Kachchh, Gujarat (15 September 2026).

Three chicks expected from Rajasthan will be reared here for about four to five months with minimal human intervention before their eventual release into the wild under established conservation protocols.

WHAT IS SOFT RELEASE?

A conservation method in which captive-bred or rehabilitated animals spend a transition period in controlled or semi-natural conditions before full release, helping them adapt to the wild and improving their survival prospects.

ABOUT GREAT INDIAN BUSTARD

- **Scientific name:** *Ardeotis nigriceps*
- **IUCN status:** Critically Endangered
- **Habitat:** Grasslands and semi-arid regions
- **Major strongholds in India:** Rajasthan and Kachchh, Gujarat
- **Major threats:** Habitat loss and fragmentation; collision with overhead power lines

KEY HABITAT AREAS

CONSERVATION PROGRESS IN KACHCHH

~11 sq km
of *Prosopis juliflora*-invaded grassland restored

~30 km
predator-proof fencing covering 15 sq km

'Jump-start' intervention
infertile eggs laid by wild females are replaced with viable eggs from the conservation-breeding programme. A chick from a recent attempt survived beyond the critical first three months.

THE PATH FROM CAPTIVITY TO THE WILD

Healthy Grasslands Support a Richer Tomorrow

PEOPLE
CONSERVATION
COEXISTENCE

INDIAN RUPEE UNDER PRESSURE

AS OIL SURGES; RBI MOVES TO ABSORB LIQUIDITY

Rising crude prices and global factors weaken the rupee, while the RBI steps in to manage volatility and absorb excess liquidity.

BRENT CRUDE
$107.7
per barrel
(15 Sept 2026)

RUPEE HITS 1-MONTH LOW

₹95.92
per US dollar
(15 Sept 2026)

Weakest level in more than a month

WHY OIL PRICES ARE RISING

- Attacks on Saudi energy infrastructure disrupted supplies
- Brent crude rose to about **$107.7** per barrel (15 Sept 2026)
- Markets expect a US Federal Reserve rate hike, adding to global uncertainty

IMPACT ON INDIA

- India is a major oil importer
- Higher crude prices can increase the import bill
- Raising inflation risks and putting pressure on the rupee

RBI'S RESPONSE

- Using dollar sales through state-run banks to curb excessive currency volatility
- Announced open-market bond sales totaling **₹1 trillion** in September 2026
- **₹500 billion** sale scheduled for 16 September

These steps aim to absorb surplus rupee liquidity from the banking system.

FOREIGN-EXCHANGE RESERVES

~$785 billion

India's forex reserves (at a record high), providing a buffer against external volatility.

10-YEAR GOVT BOND YIELD

~7.09%

Rising bond yields reflect tighter financial conditions and global spillovers.

KEY CONCEPTS

- **Currency depreciation** means the rupee buys fewer US dollars.
- **Imported inflation** occurs when a weaker currency and higher global commodity prices raise domestic costs.
- **Open Market Operations** are RBI purchases or sales of government securities to inject or absorb liquidity. Selling government bonds absorbs rupee liquidity.
- **Forex intervention** can moderate disorderly exchange-rate movements but does not imply a fixed exchange rate.

HOW IT ALL CONNECTS

Global oil shock → Higher import bill / greater dollar demand → Rupee pressure + inflation risk → RBI intervention and liquidity absorption → Attempt to contain volatility and inflationary pressure

A STABLE RUPEE SUPPORTS A STRONGER, MORE RESILIENT INDIA

INDIA'S INFLATION ACCELERATES

AUGUST 2026: CPI 4.8% | WPI 9.9%

RETAIL INFLATION (CPI)

4.8%
in August 2026

- Highest since the new CPI series began in Jan 2026
- Food inflation rose to around 6%

WHOLESALE INFLATION (WPI)

9.9%
in August 2026

- Rose sharply, driven by higher commodity and input prices
- Reflects price changes at the wholesale level

WHAT DO CPI AND WPI MEAN?

CPI (Consumer Price Index)

- Measures changes in retail prices faced by consumers
- Main inflation gauge used for monetary-policy discussion
- Headline inflation includes all CPI components (food, fuel, etc.)
- Food inflation measures changes in food prices

WPI (Wholesale Price Index)

- Tracks price changes at the wholesale level
- Basket is dominated by goods (lesser weight to services)
- Can move differently from CPI due to different baskets, weights and coverage

- 1 basis point (bps) = 0.01 percentage point

HOW HIGHER PRICES TRANSMIT THROUGH THE ECONOMY

1. Higher food, fuel and commodity prices
2. Increased wholesale and input costs
3. Higher production, transport and distribution costs
4. Partial pass-through to retail prices (CPI)
5. Pressure on household purchasing power

MONETARY POLICY CONTEXT

- Rising inflation has increased market expectations of possible monetary tightening
- Monetary policy aims to maintain price stability while keeping growth in mind.

WHY CPI AND WPI CAN DIVERGE

- Different baskets and weights (e.g., services in CPI, goods-heavy in WPI)
- Different stages of the supply chain (retail vs wholesale)
- Different coverage and price collection methodologies
- Food and fuel shocks can impact WPI earlier and pass through to CPI over time.

HIGHER INFLATION HITS HOUSEHOLDS, BUSINESSES AND THE ECONOMY

INDIA PREPARES
PM-KUSUM 2.0
WITH AGRIVOLTAICS PUSH

Same Land More Possibilities

CLEAN ENERGY STRONGER FARMERS GREENER INDIA

Union New and Renewable Energy Minister Pralhad Joshi said the government will launch a second edition of PM-KUSUM to enable farmers to generate renewable electricity alongside agricultural production.

WHAT IS AGRIVOLTAICS?

Co-locating solar photovoltaic panels and agriculture on the same land so that crops or other farm activities can continue while electricity is generated.

ABOUT PM-KUSUM

The original PM-KUSUM scheme promotes **decentralised solar** energy in agriculture, including solar power plants and solar agricultural pumps, with goals such as lower irrigation-energy costs and **additional income** opportunities for farmers.

PM-KUSUM 2.0 (ANNOUNCEMENT)

A second edition will be launched, with a dedicated **10 GW agri-photovoltaic component proposed.**

Final operational details and scheme parameters are subject to government confirmation.

HOW AGRIVOLTAICS WORKS

Farmland + elevated or appropriately spaced solar panels → Crops continue to grow below or between panels → Electricity generation → Power for farm use or grid supply → Potential additional farmer income

KEY BENEFITS

- Supplementary income for farmers
- Renewable power generation
- Lower fossil-fuel use and emissions
- Productive dual land use
- Decentralised renewable energy for rural areas

KEY CHALLENGES

- High upfront costs
- Suitable panel height and spacing
- Crop-specific effects on yield
- Grid connectivity and evacuation
- Maintenance and land-use design
- Risk of groundwater over-extraction if pumping becomes cheaper

GLOBAL FOCUS | **Agrivoltaics World Conference 2026** is scheduled in New Delhi for 21–23 October 2026.

Sustainable Farms Resilient Future

FARMERS | RENEWABLE ENERGY | FOOD SECURITY | A GREENER TOMORROW

INDIA'S AUGUST 2026 TRADE DEFICIT NARROWS

Lower gold imports help reduce the goods deficit; services exports remain strong

15 September 2026

MERCHANDISE EXPORTS (August 2026)

US$ 43.81 billion

MERCHANDISE IMPORTS (August 2026)

US$ 70.67 billion

MERCHANDISE TRADE DEFICIT (August 2026)

US$ 26.86 billion

(vs US$ 32 billion in July 2026)

GOLD IMPORTS

US$ 2.3 billion

(vs US$ 4.16 billion in July 2026)

SERVICES EXPORTS (August 2026)

US$ 38.87 billion

SERVICES TRADE SURPLUS (August 2026)

US$ 17.45 billion

COMBINED GOODS & SERVICES EXPORTS (August 2026)

US$ 82.68 billion

~25% (year-on-year)

TOP EXPORT DESTINATION (April–August 2026)

United States remained India's leading export destination

WHAT IS A TRADE DEFICIT?

Occurs when merchandise imports exceed merchandise exports.

EXPORTS → IMPORTS → If imports > exports = Trade Deficit

THE BIGGER PICTURE

The Current Account includes trade in goods and services, plus primary and secondary income.

- A strong services surplus can partly offset the **merchandise trade deficit** in the overall external account.

WHY GOLD IMPORTS MATTER?

Lower gold imports reduce pressure on the merchandise import bill.

IMPACT OF HIGH CRUDE-OIL PRICES

Higher crude-oil prices can increase India's import bill, as India is a major oil importer.

WHY THIS MATTERS?

- External-sector stability
- Rupee demand and supply
- Foreign-exchange needs
- Import dependence
- Export competitiveness
- Current-account dynamics

A Stronger External Sector Builds a Brighter India

COMMITTED INDIA CONNECTED INDIA RESILIENT INDIA

INDIA - MERCOSUR

PTA EXPANSION TALKS LAUNCHED

15 SEPT 2026

India and MERCOSUR have formally launched negotiations to expand their existing Preferential Trade Agreement.

MERCOSUR

A South American regional economic grouping

Members

- Argentina
- Brazil
- Paraguay
- Uruguay
- Bolivia (now a member)

WHAT IS A PREFERENTIAL TRADE AGREEMENT (PTA)?

- Participating countries reduce **tariffs** on a selected **list** of products.
- Unlike a full free **trade** agreement, tariffs are **not** necessarily eliminated across substantially all trade.

INDIA – MERCOSUR PTA

- In place since **2009**.
- Now, negotiations have been launched to **expand** the agreement with wider product coverage and deeper tariff preferences.

WHY EXPANSION MATTERS FOR INDIA

- Wider preferential market access in South America
- Export diversification and deeper engagement with Latin America
- Opportunities for pharmaceuticals, engineering goods, automobiles/auto components, chemicals, textiles and agricultural trade
- Domestic sectors may also face greater import competition

IMPORTANT CONCEPTS

Preferential tariff
Lower tariff rate on agreed products for partner countries.

Rules of origin
Criteria used to determine where a product originates and whether it qualifies for preferential tariff treatment.

Trade diversification
Expanding exports to new markets and across a wider range of products.

Regional trade agreement
Trade agreement among a group of countries in a region to promote trade and economic cooperation.

PATH AHEAD

India + MERCOSUR negotiate wider product coverage and tariff preferences → Lower barriers on agreed goods → More trade and supply-chain links → Stronger economic ties between India and South America

UK–INDIA TELECOM COOPERATION TO USE AI AGAINST DIGITAL FRAUD

Stronger networks. Safer users. A more secure digital future.

MoU signed on 14 September 2026

Announced by the British High Commission in New Delhi on 15 September 2026

Who signed?

UK government and the Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI)

A Memorandum of Understanding to cooperate on artificial-intelligence-enabled telecom approaches to tackle online fraud, scams and digital harms.

HOW AI HELPS IN TELECOM FRAUD DETECTION

- Analyses network patterns and unusual activity
- Identifies suspicious calls, messages and behaviour
- Helps detect and flag potential scam networks in real time
- Supports faster response by telecom operators and authorities

TELECOM CYBERSECURITY

- Protects communications networks, services and users from digital threats
- Involves threat monitoring, fraud detection, network security and user protection
- Critical for safe digital payments, online services and an inclusive digital economy

WHY CROSS-BORDER COOPERATION MATTERS

- Fraud networks, telecom routes and digital platforms often operate across countries
- Enables information and technical cooperation
- Helps deal with evolving and transnational cyber threats
- Builds shared expertise for a safer global digital ecosystem

HOW THE COOPERATION WORKS

India's telecom ecosystem + UK expertise → Information and technical cooperation → AI-assisted detection of suspicious activity → Stronger scam and fraud prevention → Safer digital communications for citizens

OPPORTUNITIES

- Faster detection of suspicious activity
- Knowledge and best-practice sharing
- Improved fraud intelligence
- Safer digital payments and communications
- Supports a trusted and inclusive digital economy

KEY CHALLENGES

- Privacy and data protection
- False positives and error risks
- Algorithmic accountability and transparency
- Cybersecurity and data misuse risks
- Jurisdictional issues in cross-border cases
- Need for responsible and ethical use of AI

WHAT AN MoU MEANS

- A Memorandum of Understanding records a framework for cooperation and intent.
- It is generally not the same as a treaty and does not, by itself, create binding international legal obligations.
- Specific projects and actions will be taken forward through further discussions and agreements.

TECHNOLOGY AGAINST FRAUD • PEOPLE AT THE CENTRE

ClearExams

LEARN • ANALYSE • STAY AHEAD

CURRENT AFFAIRS

— DAILY DIGEST —

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

KEY DEVELOPMENTS
BIGGER PICTURE
BRIGHTER PREPARATION

Facts Today A Stronger Tomorrow

POLITY & GOVERNANCE | ECONOMY | ENVIRONMENT | SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY | AGRICULTURE | INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

A MORE INFORMED YOU
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

SOCIAL SECURITY
STRONGER WORKFORCE
BRIGHTER TOMORROW

INDIA CABINET RAISES EPF WAGE CEILING TO ₹25,000

Decision to extend provident fund coverage to more salaried workers

WHAT CHANGED?

Earlier	New
₹15,000 per month	₹25,000 per month

The Union Cabinet has approved raising the wage ceiling for EPF coverage from ₹15,000 to ₹25,000.

WHAT IS EPF?

Employees' Provident Fund (EPF) is a **statutory retirement savings and social security** mechanism for eligible employees, administered by the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO).

SAVE TODAY

SECURE TOMORROW

SOCIAL SECURITY FOR A STRONGER INDIA

WHY IT MATTERS

Wider coverage

More salaried workers to be brought under EPF, especially those earning between ₹15,000 and ₹25,000.

Stronger retirement savings

Helps build long-term financial security for a larger section of workers.

Compliance impact

May lead to higher contributions and payroll adjustments for employers and employees.

LEGAL AND POLICY CONTEXT

Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952

Governs the EPF framework in India.

Directive Principles of State Policy (Article 41)

Supports the State's responsibility to provide for social security and public assistance.

WORLD OZONE DAY | 16 SEPTEMBER 2026

INDIA LAUNCHES NET ZERO PORTAL & NAPCC DASHBOARD

New digital platforms to strengthen India's climate action, monitoring and transparency

16 September 2026

Union Minister of State for Environment, Forest and Climate Change **Kirti Vardhan Singh** launched India's Net Zero Portal and NAPCC Dashboard in Mumbai on **World Ozone Day**.

Objective

To strengthen climate reporting, government monitoring, coordination, transparency and evidence-based decision-making across India's climate action.

NET ZERO PORTAL

Tracking India's Long-Term Net-Zero Transition

- Tracks and reports progress towards India's **net-zero transition**
- Brings together key data, **reports and resources**
- Helps assess progress and supports **evidence-based policy decisions**

NAPCC DASHBOARD

Monitoring India's Climate Missions

- Monitors and tracks implementation of the **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)**
- Improves coordination across different missions and stakeholders
- Enhances **transparency** and **real-time monitoring** of outcomes

What is NAPCC?

The **National Action Plan on Climate Change (NAPCC)** is India's umbrella framework for climate action, comprising multiple national missions on key areas such as solar energy, energy efficiency, sustainable habitat, water, agriculture, forests and more.

INDIA'S NET-ZERO TARGET
2070

WORLD OZONE DAY
16 SEPTEMBER
Focuses on protecting the ozone layer for a healthier planet and a safer climate.

CLIMATE ACTION TODAY
A HEALTHIER TOMORROW

PEOPLE | PLANET | PROGRESS | A SUSTAINABLE INDIA

INDIA – UAE MARITIME INDUSTRY

BUILDING A MORE CONNECTED MARITIME FUTURE

COCHIN SHIPYARD – DRYDOCKS WORLD

50 : 50 JOINT VENTURE

Stronger Ships. Stronger Seas. A Stronger Partnership.

INDIA
UAE
PEOPLE
PARTNERSHIP
PROGRESS

WHAT HAPPENED?

Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL) and Drydocks World (a DP World company, Dubai) signed a joint venture agreement on **16 September 2026** to operate, consolidate and expand the International Ship Repair Facility at Kochi, Kerala.

50 : 50 JV

- Each partner will hold **50%**.
- Builds on an MoU signed during India Maritime Week 2025.
- Described as a **first-of-its-kind public-private partnership** in India's ship-repair sector.

WHY KOCHI MATTERS

- Strategic location near major international shipping routes in the Arabian Sea.
- Modern docking and ship-lift infrastructure.
- Enables faster turnaround for Indian, regional and international vessels.

POLICY CONNECTION

- Supports the **Maritime Amrit Kaal Vision 2047**.
- Aligns with India's goal of becoming a **globally competitive shipbuilding and ship-repair hub**.
- Strengthens **India–UAE economic cooperation** in the maritime sector.

PEOPLE | PORTS | PARTNERSHIPS | PROSPERITY

A STRONGER MARITIME TOMORROW

NSE LAUNCHES ₹2.3 BILLION IPO

India's stock market giant goes public

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

WHAT HAPPENED?

India's National Stock Exchange (NSE) launched its long-awaited initial public offering (IPO) on **16 September 2026**, targeting about **US$2.3 billion**, making it one of India's largest IPOs.

IPO SNAPSHOT

Issue size
~ US$2.3 billion
(around ₹19,500 crore)

Price band
₹1,700 – ₹1,785
per share

Implied valuation
~ US$46 billion
(at upper end of the band)

OFFER FOR SALE — WHAT IT MEANS

This IPO is an **offer for sale** (OFS) by existing **shareholders**, so NSE itself does not receive fresh capital. Proceeds generally go to the selling shareholders, not the company.

IPO = first public sale/listing of a company's shares.

OFS = existing shareholders sell shares and the proceeds go to those shareholders.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR INDIA'S CAPITAL MARKETS

- Deepens India's equity markets and broadens retail participation.
- Marks a key milestone for the country's financial infrastructure.
- May improve transparency and governance through public listing norms.
- Reinforces India's position as a global financial hub.

ABOUT NSE

- World's largest derivatives exchange by trading volume.
- Options trading is a major revenue source.
- Derivatives volumes have fallen from their 2024 peak after tighter regulation and trading-rule changes.

EXAM CONCEPTS

- **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)** – India's securities-market regulator.
- **IPO, OFS,** stock exchange, capital markets, market regulation, financial infrastructure.
- **NSE**'s role in equity and derivatives markets and its significance for India's economy.

VIBRANT MARKETS STRONGER OPPORTUNITIES BRIGHTER TOMORROW

INDIA IMPLEMENTS INDIA-UK CETA AUTO TARIFF-RATE QUOTA

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

Stronger Partnership Broader Opportunities

642 UK cars approved for import under the pact

WHAT HAPPENED?

642 UK cars approved for import for the remainder of 2026 under CETA's tariff-rate-quota provisions.

7 companies granted approval by the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT).

DGFT had invited applications in July 2026 for the quota covering fully built passenger cars and goods vehicles.

WHAT IS A TARIFF RATE QUOTA (TRQ)?

TRQ

A Tariff Rate Quota allows a specified quantity of imports to enter at a lower or preferential customs duty. Imports outside the quota face the normal applicable tariff.

INDIA-UK CETA

- Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) between India and the UK.
- Entered into force on 15 July 2026.
- Includes tariff concessions for sectors such as automobiles, with quota-based and phased liberalisation.

WHY IT MATTERS

Marks the practical implementation of FTA market access commitments.

Calibrated tariff liberalisation can boost trade, investment and consumer choice.

Quota limits help manage competitive impact on domestic industry while enabling gradual opening.

KEY EXAM CONCEPTS

- Free Trade Agreement (FTA)
- Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA)
- Tariff and customs duty
- Quota and Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ)
- Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT)
- India's trade policy and market access negotiations

Open Markets Stronger Economies Shared Prosperity

INDIA CONSIDERS CUTTING EDIBLE-OIL IMPORT DUTY

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

UNDER CONSIDERATION
NOT YET A FINAL NOTIFIED DUTY CUT

India is considering a modest reduction of about **5 percentage points** in the basic import duty on **vegetable oils**.

WHY NOW?

- Domestic edible-oil prices have risen nearly **20%** over the past year.
- High food-inflation pressure, especially ahead of the festival-demand period.

INDIA'S IMPORT DEPENDENCE

India imports about **TWO-THIRDS** of its vegetable-oil requirements.

Major imports: palm oil, soybean oil and sunflower oil.

POLICY TRADE-OFF

Lower import duty could reduce consumer food costs and help contain **food inflation.**

Need to avoid **hurting domestic oilseed farmers,** especially **soybean growers.**

GLOBAL LINK

Lower Indian tariffs could increase import demand, potentially influencing international vegetable-oil prices, as India is the world's largest importer of vegetable oils.

BACKGROUND

India had already halved the basic import tax on crude edible oils in May 2025 to help ease prices.

EXAM CONCEPTS

- Import duty and tariff policy
- Food inflation and price stability
- Edible-oil import dependence of India
- Major edible oils: palm, soybean, sunflower
- Agricultural trade policy and farmer interests
- Impact of trade policy on global commodity prices

Affordable Food | Strong Farmers | Balanced Trade | A Food-Secure India

Stable Prices Stronger Tomorrow

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

CABINET APPROVES DISSOLUTION OF DIGITAL COMMUNICATIONS COMMISSION

End of a 37-year-old apex body for telecom policy coordination

WHAT CHANGED?

- Union Cabinet approved winding up the Digital Communications Commission (DCC).
- DCC to be dissolved after about 37 years.

INSTITUTIONAL HISTORY

Telecom Commission (1989) → Renamed as Digital Communications Commission (DCC) (2018) → Dissolution approved (2026)

WHAT DCC DID

- Apex inter-ministerial body for telecom policy and administrative decision-making under the Department of Telecommunications (DoT).
- Handled key issues such as spectrum, licensing, and overall telecom policy coordination across ministries.

AFTER DISSOLUTION

- Final telecom policy and administrative decisions will now be handled directly by the **Telecom Secretary**.
- Subject to approval by the Communications Minister and Cabinet where required.

Telecom Secretary → Communications Minister → Cabinet (where required)

EXAM CONCEPTS

- **Department of Telecommunications (DoT):** Union government department for telecom policy, licensing, spectrum management and overall sector development.
- **Telecom governance:** Policy-making (government) vs. regulation (TRAI) — distinct roles.
- **TRAI:** Independent statutory regulator under the TRAI Act, 1997. Not being dissolved.
- **Administrative reform:** Streamlining decision-making and reducing overlapping bodies.
- **Satellite broadband:** Growing importance in India's digital connectivity landscape.

INDIA–PAKISTAN NAVAL COLLISION

IN NORTH ARABIAN SEA

16 SEPTEMBER 2026

SAFER SEAS STRONGER STABILITY

DIALOGUE RULES REDUCE RISKS

WHAT HAPPENED?

On **15 September 2026,** an Indian Navy warship and a Pakistani naval vessel collided in international waters in the **northern Arabian Sea.**

No major damage or **casualties** were reported.

1991 AGREEMENT

ON ADVANCE NOTICE OF MILITARY ACTIVITIES

Under the **1991 India–Pakistan** Agreement on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troops Movements, naval ships and submarines of the two countries are to maintain a distance of at least **three nautical miles** from each other in international waters to avoid accidents.

DIPLOMATIC RESPONSE

- India summoned Pakistan's Charge d'Affaires on 16 September 2026.
- India said the Pakistani vessel's conduct was unacceptable and unprofessional.
- India also instructed its Charge d'Affaires in Islamabad to lodge a parallel protest.

INDIA'S POSITION

- The Pakistani vessel's conduct was unacceptable and unprofessional.
- Cited the 1991 agreement on maintaining a **3 nautical mile distance.**

PAKISTAN'S POSITION

- Disputed India's account.
- Blamed the Indian vessel for the incident.

WHY IT MATTERS

- Supports **confidence-building** measures (CBMs) between the two nations.
- Important for **maritime security** and **safe navigation.**
- Helps prevent potential escalation and crises at sea.
- Impacts overall bilateral relations and regional stability.

EXAM CONCEPTS

- **Arabian Sea** – a key maritime region in the Indian Ocean.
- **International waters** – areas beyond national jurisdiction.
- **Charge d'Affaires** – head of mission when an ambassador is not posted.
- **Confidence-building measures (CBMs)** – steps to reduce risk of conflict.
- **Bilateral military agreements** – frameworks to ensure transparency and avoid incidents.

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CURRENT AFFAIRS

DAILY DIGEST

19 SEPTEMBER 2026

TODAY'S 6 EXAM-RELEVANT UPDATES

- Environment & NGT
- Government recruitment
- India-Canada trade
- Southwest monsoon
- India growth outlook
- H-1B visa policy

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ENVIRONMENT & GOVERNANCE

NGT climate conference opens in New Delhi

Two-day international conference: 19-20 September 2026

17 COUNTRIES

Judicial representatives from 17 countries are participating.

- The National Green Tribunal (NGT) is organising the conference on 'The Future of Environment and Climate Dynamics'.
- The Prime Minister inaugurated the conference and released an NGT Mobile Application.
- Core themes include environmental governance, policy gaps, implementation, enforcement and institutional cooperation.
- Exam link: NGT is a specialised environmental adjudicatory body; environmental governance often connects law, science and federal administration.

Source PIB, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change — 19 Sep 2026

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GOVERNANCE & EMPLOYMENT

20th Rozgar Mela

Nationwide government recruitment event

51,000+

Appointment letters distributed in the 20th edition.

- The 20th Rozgar Mela was held across 45 locations in the country.
- Recruits are joining departments including Revenue, Railways, Home Affairs, Health & Family Welfare, Financial Services and Defence.
- Across 20 editions, about 12.75 lakh appointment letters have been distributed.
- Exam link: distinguish a recruitment initiative from a statutory employment-guarantee programme; recruitment continues through established agencies and sanctioned posts.

Source PIB — 19 Sep 2026; Rozgar Mela backgrounder and PMO release

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS & TRADE

India-Canada CEPA talks gain momentum

Canada says it is optimistic about concluding talks by end-2026

CEPA

Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement — broader than a basic tariff-cutting FTA.

- Canada's trade minister said Indian negotiators are expected to visit Canada next month.
- Key areas under discussion include LNG and energy, nuclear cooperation, critical minerals and resilient supply chains.
- Indian companies are exploring investment opportunities in Canadian critical-mineral projects.
- Status check: negotiations are ongoing; the year-end timeline is an objective, not a concluded agreement.

Source Reuters — 19 Sep 2026

GEOGRAPHY & CLIMATE

Southwest Monsoon withdrawal begins

IMD: withdrawal from some parts of West Rajasthan on 19 September

19 SEP

Official start of 2026 monsoon withdrawal from parts of West Rajasthan.

- Withdrawal typically starts from northwestern India and progresses toward the southeast.
- The withdrawal phase is associated with weakening monsoon circulation over northwest India and changing pressure/wind patterns.
- Exam link: 'retreating monsoon' is especially important for Tamil Nadu because the northeast monsoon later becomes its major rainy season.
- Track IMD's withdrawal line and subsequent Bay of Bengal systems separately — they can still produce heavy rain after withdrawal starts in the northwest.

Source India Meteorological Department (IMD) — Monsoon Information, 19 Sep 2026

ECONOMY

Moody's lifts India's FY27 growth forecast

Real GDP growth forecast revised upward

7.0%

Moody's FY2027 real GDP growth forecast, up from 6.0%.

- India's April-June quarter growth was reported at 7.8% year-on-year.
- Moody's cited resilience despite Middle East conflict-related pressures.
- Key risks flagged: elevated global energy prices and El Niño-related food inflation.
- Exam link: higher oil prices can affect inflation, the current account, subsidies and fiscal consolidation.

Source Reuters — 18 Sep 2026, reporting Moody's forecast

WORLD & MIGRATION

U.S. extends H-1B fee policy

One-year extension; legal challenges remain ongoing

$100,000

Fee specified for new H-1B non-immigrant visa applications under the extended order.

- The extension applies to new H-1B applications under the order; current visa holders and certain foreign graduates already in the U.S. are exempt.
- The measure is being challenged in U.S. courts, so implementation remains legally contested.
- India angle: H-1B policy is significant for Indian skilled workers and technology-sector hiring.
- Exam link: H-1B is a U.S. non-immigrant employment visa category for specialty occupations.

Source Reuters — 18 Sep 2026

A BRIGHTER INFORMED TOMORROW

Knowledge Builds Brighter Lives

CURRENT AFFAIRS DAILY DIGEST

CURIOSITY
DISCIPLINE
PROGRESS
A BRIGHTER YOU

20 SEPTEMBER 2026

PEOPLE
IDEAS
SOLUTIONS
A BETTER TOMORROW

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SLINEX-26

India and Sri Lanka at sea

- **13th edition**
- **17–21 September 2026**
- **Visakhapatnam**

PARTICIPATING SHIPS

India:
INS Kavaratti • INS Jyoti

Sri Lanka:
SLNS Sindurala

TWO PHASES

Harbour: professional exchanges and crew visits.

Sea: coordinated naval activities.

PURPOSE

Improve the two navies' ability to operate together and strengthen maritime cooperation.

REMEMBER

SLINEX was first conceptualised in 2005.

Source: Ministry of Defence / PIB
Release: 20 Sep 2026 • ID 2312662

INDIA WATER WEEK

9th India International Water Week

UPCOMING EVENT
22–26 September 2026
Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi

THEME
Climate Resilient Water Management

WHO IS ORGANISING IT?
Ministry of Jal Shakti

INTERNATIONAL PARTNERS
The Netherlands and Germany

WHAT TO WATCH
Water governance, climate risks, technology, community participation and financing.

EVENT CALENDAR
22–25 Sep: technology exhibition
22–24 Sep: international WASH conference
26 Sep: study tours

Source: Ministry of Jal Shakti / PIB
Release: 20 Sep 2026 • ID 2312634

COAL INDIA

A broader energy and minerals portfolio

FIVE AREAS OF EXPANSION

1. Coal gasification and chemicals
2. Thermal electricity generation
3. Renewables and energy storage
4. Critical minerals and advanced materials
5. Other minerals, including iron ore

PORTFOLIO SNAPSHOT

About ₹69,346 crore
Estimated cost across four coal-to-chemicals projects

About 550 MW
Solar capacity already commissioned

TECHNOLOGY TERM

BESS = Battery Energy Storage System

STATUS MATTERS

The portfolio includes both operating assets and projects under development.

Source: Ministry of Coal / PIB
Release: 20 Sep 2026 • ID 2312633

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FINANCING VIKSIT BHARAT

NEWS UPDATE

A two-day conference on development finance concluded in New Delhi on 19 September.

WHO TOOK PART?

Union and State representatives, finance officials, researchers, bankers and industry experts.

THREE PRIORITIES

- Attract more private investment.
- Prepare stronger, finance-ready projects.
- Strengthen States' capital spending.

SECTORS IN FOCUS

- Agriculture
- Energy transition
- Banking
- Technology

WHAT COMES NEXT?

Working groups with State participation will develop sector-specific financing recommendations.

DISHA 2.0

Making justice more accessible

WHY IN THE NEWS?

A regional workshop is scheduled in Goa on 21 September 2026.

DISHA MEANS

Designing Innovative Solutions for Holistic Access to Justice

SCHEME BASICS

- Central Sector Scheme
- Department of Justice
- 1 April 2026 – 31 March 2031

₹255 crore
Approved funding for 2026–31

3 crore people
Targeted cumulative outreach

DIGITAL ADDITION

VIDHI-Sanjeevani introduces a central digital platform and the **Nyaya Setu AI** chatbot.

Source: Ministry of Law & Justice / PIB
Workshop announcement: 20 Sep 2026
Scheme details: 22 Jun 2026 • ID 2276525